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Mythology construction

mythology construction *noun phrase*

Status: proposed synthetic term

Fields: cultural psychology, moral psychology, social psychology, cultural evolution, behavioural genetics, sociology of culture, sociology of morality, narrative theory, political theory, institutional design, systems leadership, social epistemology

Short explanation for busy readers

Mythology construction is the deliberate formation, adaptation, embodiment, transmission, defence, and revision of culturally transmissible systems of meaning that organize how a population perceives events, explains causes, assigns moral roles, experiences belonging, and coordinates action.

Here **mythology** does not mean merely an ancient sacred tale or a false story. It means a connected system of stories, causal explanations, topoi, values, heroes and antagonists, sacred objects, identities, roles, and expectations. Individual narratives are components of a mythology. Repeated mythologies train the **mythological lens** through which the culturally formed person rapidly experiences observations and possibilities as admirable or shameful, legitimate or illegitimate, loyal or treacherous, sacred or profane, promising or threatening. Symbols, rituals, practices, institutions, systems, and habits can embody, reinforce, contradict, or defeat those lessons, but they are not thereby reduced to mythology or exhaustively treated by this definition.

The expressions **mythology** and **mythological lens** are borrowed most directly from [Ian Macdonald, Catherine Burke, and Karl Stewart's *Systems Leadership: Creating Positive Organisations*](#). Their use here is related but not identical: Systems Leadership applies them principally to the value-laden interpretation of behaviour in organizations, whereas this definition extends them to population psychology, narrative repertoires, institutions, gene-culture hypotheses, collective agency, and adversarial cultural conflict.

Within Culture Mechanics, *Systems Leadership* is the **definitive practical source for how to implement a culture**—or, in the present theory's vocabulary, how to form and stabilize the programming of local bigOthers and the culture they reproduce. A reader who wants to know exactly how to do that should read the book rather than treating the workflow below as a complete guide. *Systems Leadership* is not about mythologies alone: leadership behaviour, systems and policies, symbols, mythologies, habits, organizational arrangements, rewards and sanctions, and repeated experience work together. Any of these other channels may be as important as mythology, or more decisive, in a particular implementation.

The originating framework's verdict is that the book's practical account is **approximately 99% correct**, meaning that it requires almost no adaptation. This is a strong qualitative judgment, not a measured validation statistic or a claim of disciplinary consensus. Its limitation for Culture Mechanics is primarily one of embedding and range: it concentrates on work, work ethics, organizational design, and company or workplace culture without placing its method in the wider account of homo duplex, bigOther processing, emergent collective fields, epistemic constitution, or population-scale cultural conflict. **bigOther** is the present framework's translation, not the Systems Leadership authors' term.

This document deliberately isolates the **mythology layer** of that larger implementation problem. It develops mythology-specific extensions and refinements; it does not provide a parallel method for designing systems, selecting symbols, forming habits, or conducting leadership in general. Mythology nevertheless has an elevated place in the theory because:

Mythologies are the assembly language of the bigOther.

This originating analogy means that evaluated stories encode persons, roles, causes, permissions, prohibitions, values, and consequences in a form close to the bigOther's learned classification operations. A repertoire of such stories can train general mappings that the bigOther applies to situations it has never encountered in narrative form. The analogy identifies a privileged cultural interface, not a claim that stories are causally sufficient or that the processor is literally digital. Assembly language still requires a working machine and execution environment. Likewise, mythology requires congruent systems, symbols, habits, conduct, sanctions, and repeated experience if its classifications are to be installed and sustained. A formally elegant mythology can fail when those other channels teach the opposite lesson.

Mythology construction is therefore more than persuasive messaging. A message asks for attention or assent. A mythology makes a world socially intelligible and gives people places within it. Its durable form is not only what a

population says, but what its members notice, feel, enact, reward, punish, teach, build, maintain, and transmit.

It also faces a **one-slot constraint**. One local bigOther executes one operative mythological weave, although that weave may combine several compatible cultural packages. An incompatible governing mythology cannot be added as a parallel evaluator or ranked at runtime; replacement requires sufficient unbraiding of the incumbent and rebraiding of one successor.

A mythology cannot be judged successful merely because it spreads. Its success has several distinguishable dimensions:

1. **Entry:** Does it resonate with the recipient population?
2. **Momentum:** What interpretations and actions does it make psychologically downhill or uphill?
3. **Destination:** Does repeated participation move toward life, capability, relationship, creation, and posterity, or toward sterile repetition, dependency, and destruction?
4. **Embodiment:** Does it become practice, character, ritual, and institution?
5. **Scale:** Can it support society-wide collective agency while preserving useful differentiation?
6. **Reality coupling:** Can evidence and consequences correct it?
7. **Replacement:** Can it defend its own braid and unbraid a failing rival without leaving a nihilistic vacuum?
8. **Agency allocation:** Who is authorized by the solidarity order to perform apologetics and polemics?
9. **Adversarial viability:** Can it resist destructive competitors without reproducing their dark arts?

The recipient-fit component is called **resonant mythology construction**. Its central hypothesis is that adoption depends partly on a fit among three components:

species-typical human machinery
x
heritable dispositional configuration
x
mythological and memetic form
↓
probability of adoption, retention, enactment, and transmission

The applied workflow derived from the broader theory is called the **Mythology Construction Toolkit**.

In one sentence:

Mythology construction is the practice of building culturally viable systems of meaning that resonate with a population, route perception into action, organize psychological energy, become embodied in institutions, and enable—or disable—reality-oriented collective agency.

Long semantic definition

1. General meaning

Mythology construction is the constructive counterpart to descriptive **culture mechanics**. **Culture mechanics** is a framework-specific term proposed in the present synthesis rather than a term attributed to an external author. It asks how mythologies train a mythological lens, how that lens supplies rapid social and moral feeling, and how people reproduce cultural order through reciprocal signalling and institutions. Mythology construction asks the next question:

Given that cultural machinery, how can a mythology be deliberately formed so that a particular society can recognize it, adopt it, embody it, coordinate through it, defend it, test it against reality, and transmit it across generations?

The term applies to deliberate projects, but it does not imply a sovereign constructor. Mythologies are altered whenever recipients retell them, institutions translate them into procedures, opponents parody them, events contradict them, or a new generation interprets inherited symbols under different conditions. Construction is consequently closer to gardening, institution-building, or protocol design than to writing an executable command for a passive machine.

A mythology constructor can:

- diagnose an existing cultural ecology;
- select and combine inherited cultural materials;
- formulate causal stories and moral classifications;

- offer identities and social roles;
- connect symbols to practices and institutions;
- create rituals of activation and renewal;
- alter rewards, sanctions, and prestige;
- form, recognize, and constrain the persons, offices, and institutions authorized to defend or contest the mythology;
- test whether recipients actually understand and enact the intended operation;
- observe material and psychological consequences;
- revise, defend, or retire a failing mythology.

The constructor cannot guarantee interpretation, adoption, or outcome. The object being shaped is a living, distributed social system whose members retain intelligence, interests, agency, memory, and the capacity for resistance.

Mythology construction is neutral as a genus. It can be used for:

- moral formation and civilizational continuity;
- ecological coordination and commons management;
- constitutional solidarity among strangers;
- organizational culture and professional ethics;
- public-health cooperation;
- commercial identity formation;
- political mobilization and hegemony;
- cultic capture, scapegoating, systemic lying, or destructive mass action.

Its normative evaluation therefore requires separate questions about truth, flourishing, freedom, justice, reversibility, and consequences.

2. Semantic anatomy

Mythology In ordinary usage, *myth* can mean a traditional sacred narrative or a false belief. Neither meaning is sufficient here.

In contemporary political, organizational, and media language, **narrative** is often used as a fuzzy synonym for **mythology**. The present framework keeps *narrative* as the broader term for an organized account of events, actors, causes, and consequences. Such an account becomes culture-mechanically mythological when it also supplies social evaluation, roles, expected feeling, or permission. A merely chronological narrative need not be a mythology; “the narrative” can, depending on context, name one evaluated story, a mythology family, or the authorized lens through which events must be interpreted.

A **mythology** in this framework is a socially evaluated system of stories and associated cultural forms through which a population learns:

- what kind of world it inhabits;
- what events resemble one another;
- who “we” are;
- what has happened to us;
- who or what causes benefit and harm;
- which persons occupy the roles of protector, producer, victim, betrayer, oppressor, teacher, ancestor, or outsider;
- what deserves gratitude, shame, loyalty, resistance, sacrifice, or protection;
- which goals can be pursued together;
- which actions are permitted, forbidden, expected, or unthinkable;
- what future would count as fulfilment, decline, liberation, or catastrophe.

A mythology may contain empirical truth, error, symbolic condensation, normative commitment, historical memory, fiction, ritual, and institutional knowledge at the same time. Calling something a mythology does not decide whether it is true or false.

One narrative can be an episode within a mythology. Many mutually reinforcing narratives form a repertoire. Their repeated evaluative patterns train a more general **mythological lens**. That lens allows a new event to be classified without replaying every previous story.

Construction **Construction** means intentional participation in the formation and reproduction of mythology. It includes selection, composition, translation, embodiment, distribution, maintenance, testing, contestation, and repair.

Construction is not confined to verbal authorship. A school timetable that rewards punctuality, a court that visibly follows due process, an initiation ritual, a public memorial, a promotion rule, a marriage norm, an agricultural calendar, or an institution that honours truthful correction can construct mythology more durably than a speech.

The word also emphasizes that cultural order is made and remade. It does not imply that every feature was designed, that inherited practices lack real functions, or that an unconstrained designer can reconstruct society without loss.

Society or population The intended recipient is a **society** in a broadly Durkheimian sense: a population whose members participate in a shared moral and symbolic order, not merely a statistical collection of individuals.

The society may be:

- a family or local community;
- a profession or organization;
- a religious body;
- a political movement;
- a region, nation, or civilization;
- a transnational network;
- a temporary public assembled around an event.

The relevant boundary is functional: across which population must shared classifications travel for the desired cooperation to become possible?

Resonance **Resonance** is the experienced fit between a mythology and the recipient's existing psychological, moral, motivational, historical, and institutional configuration.

A mythology resonates when recipients experience it not as arbitrary alien material but as a compelling recognition, clarification, elevation, or completion of something already latent in their perception and dispositions. Resonance can produce attention, narrative transportation, moral emotion, identity, recall, and willingness to act.

Resonance is not agreement with every proposition. A mythology can resonate by naming an unease, honouring an unrecognized motive, explaining a recurring experience, or offering a role for which a person already feels prepared.

Resonance is also not proof. A false and destructive mythology may resonate powerfully; a true and beneficial account may initially fail because it lacks a culturally intelligible form.

Toolkit The **Mythology Construction Toolkit** is the practical set of diagnostic maps, canvases, design procedures, experiments, institutional checks, and adversarial audits derived from the mythology-specific theory. It guides work on the mythology layer. It does not claim to cover systems, symbols, habits, or the other culture-implementation channels in their own right; the definitive complete method remains *Systems Leadership*.

The **software-development-kit analogy** makes the relationship tangible. An SDK does not dictate one finished application; it exposes reusable operations from which many applications can be built. In the same way, causal-story canvases, resonance maps, role design, ritual design, institutional checks, and adversarial audits expose operations for working on the culturally installed classifier called the bigOther. The analogy has a limit: people are not passive processors. They interpret, refuse, modify, and sometimes reverse the intended operation. A legitimate toolkit must therefore include agency, inspectability, correction, and exit rather than treating compliance as successful execution.

3. Terminological neighbours and prior art

Mythology construction overlaps with several established fields without being identical to any one of them.

Neighbouring concept	Primary object	Relation to mythology construction
Narrative design	Narratives, public meaning, and their reception	Common practitioner-language near-synonym for mythology construction at the intervention level; supplies plot, character, transportation, and sequencing methods, but may stop before institutional embodiment.
Framing	Selection and salience in presenting an issue	Supplies interpretive emphasis; mythology construction joins many frames into a durable moral world.
Rhetoric and persuasion	Change in attention, attitude, or decision	Supplies message-level operations; mythology construction includes socialization, identity, ritual, and institutions.
Ideology	System of political or social ideas	Often names the propositional or justificatory layer; mythology includes affect, symbol, practice, and tacit role formation.
Propaganda	Organized persuasive communication, often strategic	Can be one implementation mode, especially when manipulative; mythology construction is the broader neutral genus.
Apologetics and polemics	Defence of a belief system and contestation of rival belief	Supplies the paired functions of maintaining one's own mythology and unbraiding a competitor; the present framework generalizes theological terms beyond religion.
Psychoanalysis	Interpretation of unconscious formations, symptoms, resistance, and repetition	Supplies a suggestive model of structured untying; its use as mythology-level deprogramming is an analogy, not Freud's own social theory.
Critical Theory and critique	Diagnosis of contradiction, domination, and historically contingent social order	Supplies polemical tools for making an inherited order questionable; mythology construction adds the burden of replacement and tests whether critique is reality-coupled or indiscriminately corrosive.
Discourse and hegemony	Contingent articulation of meaning, identity, and political boundaries	Supplies tools for equivalential chains, antagonism, nodal points, and contestation.
Organizational culture	Shared assumptions and learned ways of acting	Supplies concrete embedding mechanisms through leadership, selection, reward, ritual, and response to crisis.
Cultural evolution	Differential transmission and retention of cultural variants	Supplies population-level models of inheritance, selection, and gene–culture feedback.

[Robert Entman's account of framing](#) emphasizes selection and salience in defining problems, diagnosing causes, making moral judgments, and suggesting remedies. [George Lakoff's work on conceptual framing](#) emphasizes that political communication operates through structured concepts rather than isolated words. [Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe's theory of hegemony](#) treats collective identities and political unities as contingent articulations rather than ready-made essences.

The theological vocabulary is used here in a deliberately generalized sense. [John G. Stackhouse](#) distinguishes defensive apologetics, which answers challenges, from an offensive mode that provokes interest. Older theological

classifications also distinguish apologetics from polemics directed against error, although the boundary varies among traditions. Mythology construction abstracts the functional contrast: **apologetics defends and repairs an installed mythology; polemics attacks and unbraid a rival mythology**. These definitions are not claimed as the uniquely correct theological meanings of the words.

These traditions help explain construction grammar, maintenance, and contestation. The present synthesis adds a three-component resonance model, psychological-gradient analysis, sublimation and moral formation, coupling range, lifted mechanical solidarity, reality coupling, and a complete braid–unbraid–rebraid model of mythological replacement.

Existing practical tools such as the [Butterfly Lab Narrative Design Toolkit](#), the [Counter-Narrative Handbook](#), and [Story-based Strategy](#) can be understood as partial software-development kits for changing contested cultural classification. They are prior art, not complete equivalents of the framework defined here.

Their vocabulary makes the terminological overlap concrete. In contemporary practice, **narrative design** and **narrative construction** name substantially the same intervention domain that this framework calls **mythology construction**: forming stories, causal interpretations, identities, roles, values, and expected responses so that a population perceives and acts differently. The term *mythology construction* is retained because it makes the culture-programming and evaluative function explicit and follows the narrative into symbols, rituals, practices, institutions, and the mythological lens. The toolkits remain partial rather than complete equivalents because none by itself supplies this framework’s whole ontology, embodiment account, epistemic safeguards, or relationship to Systems Leadership.

4. Place within the wider framework

Mythology construction joins four layers that should remain distinguishable:

CULTURE MECHANICS

How mythologies program evaluative perception and coordination



MYTHOLOGY CONSTRUCTION

How culturally viable mythologies are deliberately formed and embodied



EPISTEMIC AGENCY AND CONSTITUTION

Who may inspect, reject, revise, and correct the installed order



LINGUISTIC-TRICKS AUDIT

Which local operations corrupt meaning, attribution, and discussion

In this synthesis, **epistemic agency** means the person’s and group’s ability to understand, inspect, and revise socially supplied judgments. **Epistemic constitution** means the society-wide rules governing authority, avowal, evidence, disagreement, memory, and correction. **Adversarial linguistic audit** means the inspection of recurring micro-level operations through which communication can be made strategically misleading or correction-resistant. These are framework-specific operational uses, not definitions borrowed unchanged from one external author.

Mythology construction operates between them. It can create cultural forms that strengthen agency and correction, or forms that capture them.

The framework’s basic culture-mechanical sequence is:

mythologies and institutions



mythological lens



social and moral classification



attention, emotion, judgment, and action



visible conduct and reciprocal signalling



distributed cultural reinforcement or change

Mythology construction intervenes at every stage rather than merely at the first line.

5. What is being constructed

A mythology is a structured configuration, not a bag of slogans. Its major design objects include:

Design object	Guiding question
World model	What kind of world do participants inhabit?
Historical memory	What happened, what was inherited, and what remains unfinished?
Desired world	What future would constitute fulfilment or flourishing?
Feared world	What decline, domination, betrayal, or dissolution must be avoided?
Topoi	Which recurring situations and recognisable commonplaces organize interpretation?
Plot or mythos	By what causal sequence did the present arise, and how can it change?
Moral grammar	Which dimensions of care, proportionality, loyalty, authority, purity, equality, property, or liberty are activated?
Causal stories	What or who produced the condition, with what intention and responsibility?
Characters	Who acts as protagonist, beneficiary, victim, guardian, producer, obstacle, or antagonist?
Sacred objects	What may not be traded away without moral desecration?
Master signifiers	Which compact terms organize otherwise diverse demands and identities?
Identity offer	Who can the recipient become by entering the mythology?
Role offer	What concrete contribution can that person perform?
Permission structure	What may, must, or must not be done?
Practices and rituals	How is the mythology repeatedly enacted and renewed?
Institutional embodiment	Which offices, rules, rewards, and material systems reproduce it?
Actor architecture	Which persons, offices, or institutions may authoritatively defend, interpret, attack, repair, or replace it?
Reality interface	What outcomes, observations, or failures can correct it?
Exit and repair	How can error be admitted, harm repaired, and participation ended?

These components need not all be explicit. The more important the mythology, the more likely its decisive knowledge is stored in habitual action, institutional design, calendar, etiquette, architecture, and remembered example rather than in a single canonical text.

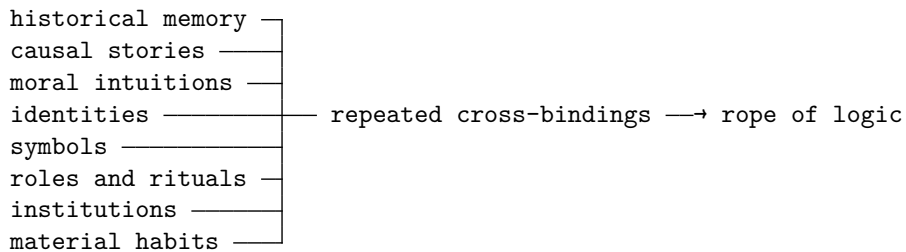
5.1 Mythological replacement: braiding, apologetics, and polemics Mythology construction is not only the production of new material. It also concerns the **replacement problem**: how one governing mythology loses authority and another acquires it.

The framework proposes a **one-slot hypothesis**: one local bigOther occupies the one PCI slot and executes one operative mythological lens. A person can entertain many stories, roles, schemas, identities, and alternative worldviews in memory and reflective thought. The operative lens may likewise be a complex braid assembled from several compatible programming packages or libraries. But these are not independent local bigOthers or governing programs awaiting a higher runtime rule that ranks them. Their operative meanings and relations are already produced within the one installed weave. The PCI analogy describes exclusive occupancy by one evaluator, not literal neuroanatomy, simplicity of the program, or cultural purity.

Compatibility concerns load-bearing classifications and authority relations, not mere similarity. As *Culture Mechanics*, “The single-slot principle,” illustrates, Paul’s pride in supporting himself through work shows how Christianity

and a *Berufsethos* can reinforce one another inside one weave rather than compete for supremacy. Conversely, the originating framework states that Christianity and the National Socialist worldview are deeply incompatible programming systems. Nazi programming could not be installed beside an intact Christian program. Capture required the incumbent Christian braid to be loosened and unbraided sufficiently for retained and new strands to be rebraided into one Nazi-governed successor.

An installed mythology is best pictured as a braid:



A single strand is weak. Repeatedly crossing the strands makes the whole structure strong, flexible, durable, and redundant. A historical story supports a moral judgment; the judgment honours an identity; the identity performs a ritual; the ritual authorizes an institution; the institution makes the historical story visible again. No single proposition need carry the entire load. If one strand frays, neighbouring strands preserve the pattern.

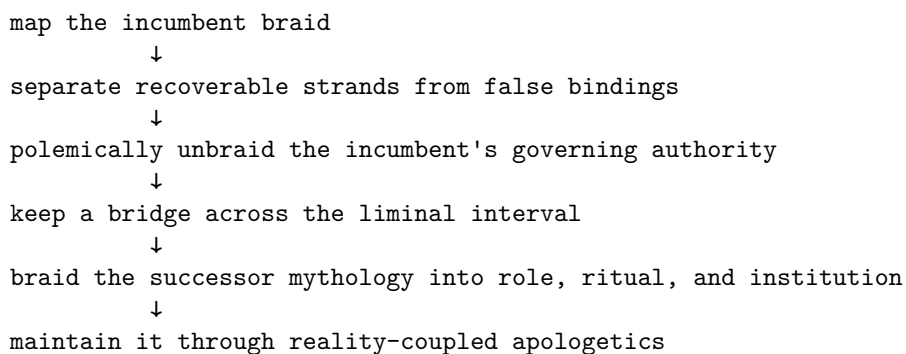
The more human image is a mother braiding her daughter's hair. Her hands repeatedly cross flexible strands that would otherwise drift apart, producing a form stronger, more orderly, and more durable than any strand alone. Mythological formation similarly turns many stories, habits, values, and expectations into a structure that can survive movement and local damage without becoming rigid.

Without such formation, culturally supplied meanings may instead resemble a box of tangled cables: fragments of injunction, desire, fear, memory, and borrowed language cross one another without traceable structure. The result can be a Gordian knot or **spaghetti code** in the co-processor—difficult to inspect, debug, or deliberately revise. Braiding is structured cultural programming: it does not eliminate complexity, but gives the strands a discoverable relation and a durable direction.

This produces two indispensable operations:

- **Mythological apologetics** defends, explains, repairs, and renews the braid. It answers objections, clarifies apparent contradictions, reconnects inherited symbols to living practices, and removes obstacles to justified confidence.
- **Mythological polemics** attacks and unbraids a rival braid. It identifies load-bearing strands, separates associations that had seemed natural, exposes false causal links or contradictory permissions, and withdraws authority from a mythology that is to be displaced.

Polemics is crucial because an incompatible successor mythology cannot simply be placed beside an incumbent that still occupies the slot. The incumbent tells recipients how to classify the newcomer and may mark it as absurd, immoral, impure, treacherous, or literally unintelligible. Construction therefore includes a controlled sequence of dissolution and reconstruction:



The bridge matters. Pure unbraiding can destroy confidence more quickly than a constructive replacement can grow. It may leave cynicism, anomie, or raw first-order identity to occupy the vacancy. Effective polemics therefore does not merely say that the old order is bad. It distinguishes what is false or destructive from what remains true, functional, or worthy of inheritance, and it accepts responsibility for the successor order its critique makes possible.

Replacement need not erase every incumbent strand. Words, symbols, memories, rituals, offices, practices, and self-descriptions may be preserved, but their operative meaning comes from their bindings within the successor weave. A Nazi-Christian successor is therefore one rebraided program, not a Nazi program ranked above an intact Christian program. Failed or incomplete replacement may produce contradiction, instability, or spaghetti code in one tangled lens; it does not produce several simultaneously operative bigOthers.

5.2 Who performs apologetics and polemics? Apologetics and polemics are not performed by an abstract mythology acting without carriers. They require an **actor**, but the actor is not always an autonomous individual and need not be the person whose mouth or pen produces the visible statement. The relevant actor is the person, office, or institution whose intervention the solidarity order recognizes as having authority to defend, interpret, attack, condemn, repair, or replace mythology.

In **first-order mechanical solidarity**, authority is commonly personalized. A priest, clan chief, elder, shaman, bard, prophet, or other singular figure may embody the group's memory and sacred distinctions. The person's lineage, initiation, charisma, age, demonstrated courage, ritual position, or inherited office makes the person a focal node of the common consciousness:

```
first-order mythology
↓
recognized sacred or political person
↓
defence of the group's braid + attack on rival braid
```

Here it may be difficult to separate person from office. An attack upon the chief or priest can be experienced as an attack upon the group, while the person's defence of the mythology carries force because the group recognizes that person as one of its authoritative embodiments.

In **lifted mechanical solidarity**, apologetic and polemical agency can migrate from a singular person to an institution. A court, church, university, academy, professional body, newspaper, parliament, party, ministry, or constitutional office can defend the meta-order, interpret its canonical terms, reject rival claims, and sanction violations. Humans still speak, write, judge, and enforce, but they do so as officeholders, organs, or representatives of an actor that persists beyond them:

```
lifted civic or professional mythology
↓
institution with office, memory, procedure, jurisdiction, and succession
↓
replaceable human representatives
↓
apologetic and polemical intervention carrying institutional authority
```

Calling the institution the **real actor** does not erase human action or attribute a supernatural mind to an organization. It identifies where durable authority, memory, procedure, resources, reputation, and continuity reside. The individual judge, editor, professor, bishop, or civil servant may leave while the institution continues to speak and act in a recognizably continuous way.

The framework further proposes that apologetic and polemical actors are partly **selected by the solidarity field**. The mythology creates recognizable positions or **systemic slots**: guardian of orthodoxy, authoritative interpreter, reconciler, prosecutor, boundary keeper, heresy hunter, reformer, or polemicist. People differ in how strongly those positions attract them and in how credible they appear once they approach them.

```
mythology and solidarity order create a systemic slot
↓
the slot offers a recognizable duty, danger, status, and permission
↓
persons differ in dispositional fit
↓
some gravitate toward training, conflict, office, or public advocacy
↓
group or institution recognizes, ratifies, appoints, or rejects them
↓
actor-slot coupling
```

↓

authorized apologetic or polemical agency

○

the actor reinforces or modifies the field that selected the actor

Relevant dispositions may include sensitivity to incoherence or boundary violation, loyalty, aggression, verbal ability, courage under conflict, desire for order, status motivation, institutional temperament, historical memory, and willingness to bear the costs of public defence. Apologetic roles may disproportionately attract people oriented toward continuity, integration, explanation, and repair. Polemical roles may disproportionately attract people oriented toward threat detection, semantic decomposition, boundary enforcement, confrontation, and attack. The same person or institution can combine both functions, but the dispositional profiles need not be identical.

This is the **natural-choice hypothesis** in a precise sense. A person can choose to study, prepare, campaign, seek office, or attempt an intervention. The person cannot by private decision alone make the intervention carry the authority of the solidarity order. Self-appointment creates a claimant; effective apologetic or polemical authority requires reciprocal coupling between person and slot:

personal choice and preparation
+
dispositional and symbolic fit
+
recognition by the relevant group or institution
=
systemically effective actor

“Natural choice” does not mean that one genetically predetermined individual is destined for the position. It means that, among available persons, the interaction of disposition, biography, competence, network position, symbolic credibility, institutional need, and collective recognition makes some candidates more likely than others to occupy the slot successfully.

The E–M-field analogy therefore applies to agency as well as resonance. The solidarity field creates gradients and positions toward which fitting actors move; the actors then strengthen, redirect, or destabilize the field. They are simultaneously products, carriers, and modifiers of the mythology.

Systemic selection is not automatically wise. A corrupt or death-driven mythology may select gifted rationalizers, persecutors, or dark artists because their dispositions fit the pathological slot it offers. A lifted institution may also become self-protective and select representatives who defend organizational survival rather than the institution’s stated purpose. Actor selection must therefore be evaluated by reality coupling and institutional consequence, not merely by the intensity of recognition.

6. The dimensions of mythological success

Mythology construction uses a multidimensional definition of success.

Entry: resonance Does the mythology activate existing human machinery and fit the population’s dispositional and cultural configuration sufficiently to gain attention, recognition, and initial adoption?

Momentum: psychological gradient Once entered, which interpretations and actions become easier to repeat? Does the mythology supply immediate relief, belonging, certainty, and catharsis, or does it make discipline, truthfulness, service, and mastery increasingly meaningful?

Destination: drive direction What does the path cumulatively produce? Does repetition increase capability, relationship, creation, maintenance, and posterity, or dependency, sterile repetition, resentment, and destruction?

Embodiment: cultural durability Does the mythology become a stable part of character, practice, ritual, selection, reward, institution, and material environment?

Scale: collective agency Does the mythology travel across the population required for cooperation? Does it build shared second-order meaning or merely intensify local subcultures?

Reality coupling: adaptive correction Can evidence, failed prediction, ecological consequence, human suffering, exit, and comparison correct the mythology? Or does every failure generate only a demand for greater commitment?

Replacement: apologetics and polemics Can the mythology explain and repair its own braid under challenge? If it must replace an incumbent order, can it identify and unbraid the incumbent's false or failing bindings while preserving recoverable knowledge, continuity, and a credible route into the successor? Does its polemic open a constructive future, or merely dissolve trust in every available order?

Agency allocation: actor-slot coupling Who occupies the apologetic and polemical slots, and why does the solidarity order recognize that person, office, or institution? Does authority depend upon personal embodiment, institutional office, or both? Can succession preserve legitimate agency without turning the role into either charismatic personal rule or self-protective institutional closure?

Adversarial viability: competition and defence Can the mythology survive parody, hostile reframing, semantic capture, demoralization, and psychologically cheaper competitors? Can it defend itself without becoming deceptive, self-sealing, or persecutory?

The dimensions can diverge. A mythology can be highly resonant, psychologically downhill, institutionally durable, society-wide, and catastrophically reality-detached. Another can be true and beneficial but culturally inert. Construction seeks a viable combination rather than maximizing a single variable.

Recipient fit: resonant mythology construction

7. The three-component resonance model

The proposed model collapses the apparent complexity of recipient fit into three interacting components.

7.1 Species-typical human machinery Human beings share broadly similar evolved capacities that make mythology possible:

- sensitivity to harm, reciprocity, loyalty, rank, purity, property, equality, and domination;
- narrative comprehension and transportation;
- imitation, prestige learning, and conformity;
- attachment, identification, and coalition formation;
- authority sensitivity and reactance;
- sacred-value formation;
- emotional contagion and synchrony;
- causal inference and agency detection;
- status seeking and reputation management;
- ritual participation and collective effervescence.

Moral Foundations Theory—developed principally by Jonathan Haidt, Craig Joseph, Jesse Graham, and collaborators—treats moral foundations as evolved psychological preparations elaborated by culture. The present framework borrows the metaphor of **moral taste buds** and the formulation, emphasized in [Haidt's *The Righteous Mind*](#), that biology supplies a first draft rather than a finished moral text. Common receptors can be differently weighted and culturally trained. The framework also extends the metaphor beyond the current list of moral foundations; the complete species-typical machinery includes narrative, motivational, social-learning, and collective-coordination capacities.

The culinary image captures both commonality and difference. People may possess broadly similar taste receptors while preferring different cuisines, intensities, and combinations because receptor sensitivity, development, and learning differ. A mythology constructor is therefore like a cook who must understand both the available receptors and the formed palate. The dish that produces the strongest first sensation is not necessarily the one that nourishes, and a familiar recipe may fail when transported unchanged into another culinary culture.

[Melanie Green and Timothy Brock's work on narrative transportation](#) helps explain how attention, emotion, and imagery can temporarily organize recipients inside a narrative world. Transportation is one mechanism of entry, not the entire resonance process.

7.2 Heritable dispositional configuration Within the shared architecture, people differ in thresholds, weightings, sensitivities, motives, temperaments, and capacities. The theory proposes that part of this variation is heritable and highly polygenic.

Candidate dispositions include:

- individualism and collectivism;
- autonomy and reactance;
- care and threat sensitivity;
- proportionality and cheating detection;
- equality and anti-dominance sensitivity;
- loyalty, authority, purity, order, and property sensitivity;
- novelty seeking and uncertainty tolerance;
- affiliation, status, power, tranquillity, honour, and curiosity;
- preference for personal versus impersonal trust;
- producer-like and guardian-like orientations.

A **polygenic score** combines the small estimated associations of many genetic variants into a probabilistic index for a trait or outcome. [Robert Plomin's *Blueprint*](#) popularizes the relevance of highly polygenic inheritance for psychological differences. A score is neither an essence nor an individual destiny. Its proposed role here is predictive: future scores may help explain why different people respond differently to the same mythological configuration.

The useful image is **gold dust rather than a single nugget**. Each measured variant contributes, at most, a minute weighted signal. Aggregating many such specks can produce a probabilistic population-level prediction, but it does not reveal a hidden “individualism gene,” determine one person’s response, or eliminate the importance of culture and situation.

The framework therefore includes, as real research hypotheses:

- that mythology receptivity has partly heritable components;
- that future polygenic scores may predict differential receptivity;
- that scores may add predictive information beyond demographics and self-report;
- that population histories may alter the distribution of relevant dispositions;
- that producer-like and egalitarian-guardian-like configurations may prove to be partly heritable clusters.

These hypotheses are not removed because current scores are incomplete. Their absence from present measurement defines work to be done. At the same time, current construction practice must diagnose expressed traits rather than pretend to read unmeasured genotypes.

7.3 Mythological and memetic configuration The third component is the cultural form offered to the recipient. It includes the mythology’s moral weighting, causal model, identity, roles, status economy, authorities, symbols, practices, institutions, and psychological rewards.

A mythology has a meaningful chance of adoption when it:

- activates shared human capacities;
- fits the recipient’s dispositional weighting;
- explains experience through a plausible causal worldview;
- offers satisfying but enactable motives and roles;
- uses trusted symbols and messengers;
- becomes compatible with the recipient’s social network and institutions;
- supplies an environment in which the newly adopted identity can be reinforced.

The three components meet recursively:

COMMON HUMAN MACHINERY

provides the possible receptors and learning capacities

↓

HERITABLE DISPOSITIONAL CONFIGURATION

weights sensitivities, motives, thresholds, and niche preferences

↓

MYTHOLOGICAL CONFIGURATION

activates, interprets, rewards, and socially organizes those tendencies

↓

8. The observable resonance surface

The operational interface of the three-component model is multidimensional:

**expressed dispositions × moral intuitions × motives × causal worldview × group identity × authority
structure × institutions × situation**

These dimensions are not eight foundations competing with genetics. They are observable forms through which common machinery, dispositional variation, and cultural programming meet.

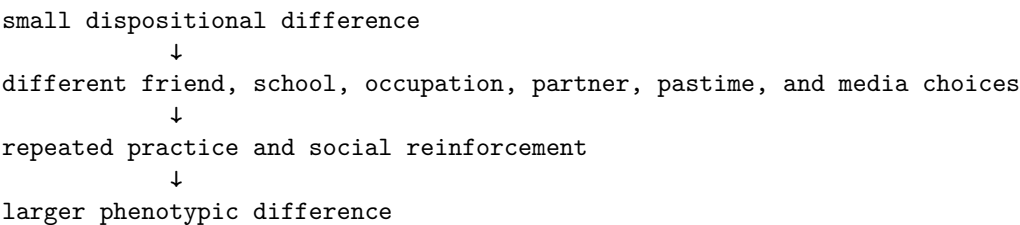
Surface dimension	Diagnostic question
Expressed dispositions	What patterns of temperament, autonomy, trust, threat response, and cooperation are repeatedly visible?
Moral intuitions	Which violations produce immediate care, anger, disgust, betrayal, cheating, oppression, or encroachment responses?
Motives	Which forms of belonging, status, order, independence, power, curiosity, honour, or tranquillity are sought?
Causal worldview	Are people disposed toward constrained trade-offs, systemic redesign, providence, fate, conspiracy, personal agency, or impersonal mechanism?
Group identity	Which “we” already commands loyalty, shame, memory, and sacrifice?
Authority structure	Who may name events, certify knowledge, settle disputes, and grant legitimacy?
Institutions	Which rules, rituals, roles, and incentives already embody the culture?
Situation	Which event, threat, opportunity, humiliation, or crisis is activating the configuration now?

The same recipient may occupy different positions across domains. A person can prefer impersonal accounting in commerce, intimate need-based sharing in family life, hierarchy in a military role, and egalitarian discussion among friends. Resonance mapping must therefore be situational and role-sensitive rather than reducing a person to one ideological label.

9. Developmental amplification and active niche selection

The theory adopts **active gene–environment correlation** as a developmental mechanism. [Robert Plomin, John DeFries, and John Loehlin’s early formulation](#) distinguishes ways in which genotypes and environments can become correlated; [Sandra Scarr and Kathleen McCartney](#) subsequently developed the active form into a theory of how people increasingly select and construct their own environments. Mythology construction borrows this mechanism but extends the object of selection to mythological repertoires, identities, institutions, and culturally marked niches. This usage is compatible with, but not identical to, [John Odling-Smee, Kevin Laland, and Marcus Feldman’s evolutionary niche-construction theory](#), which concerns organisms’ modification of selective environments and ecological inheritance.

As people gain autonomy, they increasingly select, modify, and create environments that fit their dispositions:



↓
stronger preference for congruent environments
↻

Mythologies can become cultural niche-selection devices. They tell people where “someone like me” belongs, which occupation is honourable, which partner is admirable, which community feels safe, and which costs are meaningful. Adoption therefore changes not only belief but the environments that will shape later belief.

This produces an **age-amplification hypothesis**:

Differences in mythology receptivity may become more visible with age when people increasingly construct lives that express and reinforce their dispositions.

The hypothesis does not require every disposition to grow monotonically. Institutions, trauma, conversion, migration, education, and deliberate self-formation can redirect development. It predicts a tendency toward self-selected amplification, not an irreversible fate.

The cultural-meta-environment hypothesis Behavioural-genetic variance components and adoption studies often find that growing up in one household explains less of the variation among people than ordinary nurture theories predict. The present framework proposes that this does not exhaust systematic environmental formation.

A society-wide bigOther may shape nearly everyone while contributing little to measured differences between siblings. Individuals can also encounter that same cultural system through different peers, events, authorities, roles, and self-selected niches. A patterned population-level influence may therefore appear statistically as non-shared experience at the individual level.

The proposed **cultural-meta-environment hypothesis** is:

Some systematic non-genetic formation operates through the distributed cultural environment rather than through the shared household, while dispositional niche selection determines which parts of that environment become formative for each person.

This hypothesis does not simply rename all non-shared environmental variance “the bigOther.” It predicts identifiable pathways—media, institutions, peer networks, rituals, local authorities, historical events, and selected niches—through which society-wide mythology produces patterned but individually different exposure.

10. Gene–culture coevolution

Genes and culture form interacting inheritance systems. The quantitative research programme was pioneered by [L. Luca Cavalli-Sforza and Marcus Feldman](#) and developed in dual-inheritance theory by Robert Boyd and Peter Richerson. [Peter Richerson, Robert Boyd, and Joseph Henrich](#) review gene–culture coevolution in the genomic era; [Joseph and Natalie Henrich](#) apply the approach to human cooperation. The present framework borrows the reciprocal gene–culture mechanism but makes differential **mythology receptivity** its specific, still hypothetical, target.

The **electromagnetic-wave analogy** expresses the intended reciprocity. In an electromagnetic wave, changing electric and magnetic fields belong to one propagating process; neither is merely an inert passenger behind the other. Likewise, inherited dispositions help select mythologies, while durable mythologies construct environments that can alter later biological selection. Genes and mythologies are not literally fields, and their transmission rules and timescales remain different. The analogy serves only to resist a one-way picture in which either biology writes culture or culture writes on biologically blank recipients.

The mythology-construction model proposes the following long feedback loop:

inherited dispositional distribution
↓
differential resonance and cultural adoption
↓
institutions, status systems, partner choice, and social niches
↓
differences in survival, reproduction, migration, and prestige
↓
altered cultural and potentially genetic selection pressures
↓

later dispositional distribution



This is the sense in which biological evolution and mythological evolution can be said to beget one another. The two systems operate at different speeds and through different transmission rules, yet each helps form the environment in which the other is selected.

The model permits a **fast-evolution hypothesis**: where cultural selection pressures remain strong and directionally stable, biologically relevant population change need not be confined to prehistory. Partner choice, fertility, migration, survival, and status can alter the distribution of dispositions across historical time. This is a proposed mechanism to test, not a warrant for inferring a genetic change whenever a culture changes quickly.

A deliberately simple **punctuality example** shows the complete loop. Suppose some members of a population are more disposed toward temporal regularity. A mythology interprets punctuality as respect, reliability, or honour; schools and workplaces reward it; people then select occupations, friends, and partners for whom it matters. Repeated selection makes the disposition more visible with age and stabilizes institutions built around it. If partner choice, status, migration, or fertility also differs systematically, the arrangement could eventually affect selection pressures. The early cultural and behavioural links can be observed now. The final population-genetic link remains a hypothesis requiring direct evidence; no “punctuality score” is assumed.

The framework includes a **population-history hypothesis**:

Societies with different histories of kinship, religion, institutions, partner choice, migration, and cultural selection may differ partly in dispositional distributions, making the same mythology differently resonant across populations.

This hypothesis is probabilistic and population-level. It does not license deduction from group membership to individual character. Its intended scientific test is prospective prediction of differential response, not retrospective storytelling fitted to any observed difference.

10.1 Worked behavioural-genetic examples and hypothesis ladder The genetic component should not disappear behind ritual cautions. The point of including it is to make risky predictions that can succeed or fail. The following examples range deliberately from established behavioural-genetic observations through mechanism proposals to strong, currently unconfirmed hypotheses.

1. Adoption, body weight, and the location of environment In his account of the Colorado Adoption Project, [Robert Plomin](#) uses body weight to make the shared-environment result visible:

Relationship	Approximate reported correlation for weight
Adopted child ↔ adoptive parent	0
Two unrelated children adopted into one household	0
Adopted child ↔ biological mother	0.3
Biologically related siblings	0.3

Plomin uses the parent–offspring correlation of roughly 0.3 to illustrate an estimate around 60% heritability, because parent and child share about half their segregating DNA. In this example, the remaining variation is environmental, but the shared household contributes little to differences in weight among the adopted children. The result is striking precisely because the adoptive parents put the food on the table.

The mythology-construction interpretation is sharper than “environment is random.” The originating criticism is that behavioural genetics may be looking for systematic environment at the wrong scale. If a bigOther supplies society-wide classifications, aspirations, prohibitions, status systems, and institutions, it may shape nearly everyone without making siblings more alike. Active niche selection can then route genetically different recipients through different regions of the same cultural meta-environment. What appears as non-shared environment at household scale may contain patterned cultural formation at society scale.

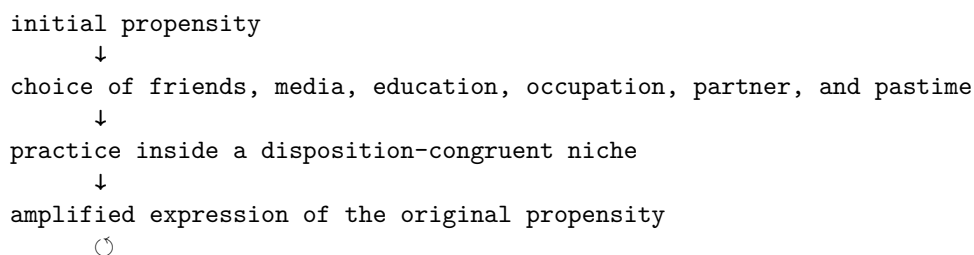
Weight is an illustration, not proof of this claim for mythology. Heritability describes variation in a specified population and environment; it does not divide an individual into genetic and environmental percentages. The testable extension is whether measurable cultural pathways explain otherwise residual differences in mythology receptivity.

2. Religious and political belief as a shared-environment exception A loose paraphrase of [Plomin's discussion in Blueprint](#) would say that parents have roughly a “20% chance” of transmitting religious belief. The statistical claim is different: for some religious and political beliefs, shared environment accounts for about **20% of variance**, an exception to the near-zero shared-environment estimates reported for many psychological traits.

That exception points directly toward mythology. Religion and politics are among the domains in which families deliberately name authorities, repeat stories, perform rituals, regulate affiliation, and connect the child to a wider bigOther. The number does not identify a simple parental transmission rate, nor does it prove that the remaining environmental variance is cultural. It shows that socially organized belief can leave a detectable shared-environment signal and makes the larger cultural-meta-environment hypothesis worth testing.

3. Age amplification and active niche construction The strongest documented developmental example is cognitive ability. Plomin summarizes longitudinal adoption, twin, and meta-analytic results in which the heritability of intelligence rises from childhood toward adulthood. A [meta-analysis of longitudinal twin and adoption studies](#) examines this increasing heritability and genetic amplification.

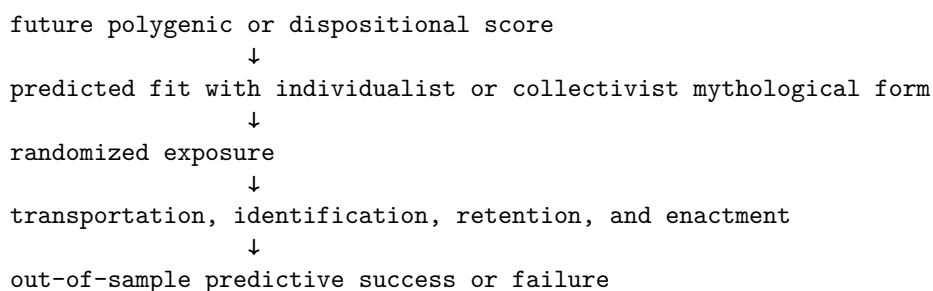
The proposed mechanism is not that DNA changes with age. It is that autonomy increases:



This pattern should not be asserted identically for every trait; Plomin notes that personality and school achievement do not show the same developmental curve as intelligence. Mythology construction turns active niche selection into a direct research question: do initially small differences in mythology receptivity grow as people build lives around congruent identities, institutions, and networks?

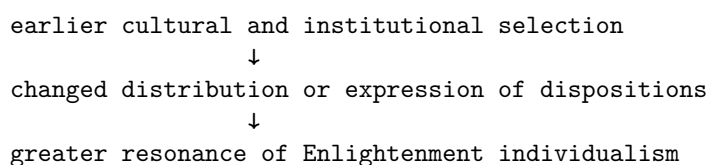
4. A polygenic score for individualism and mythology receptivity No validated population polygenic score for “individualism” is assumed here. That absence is not a reason to delete the mechanism; it defines the target.

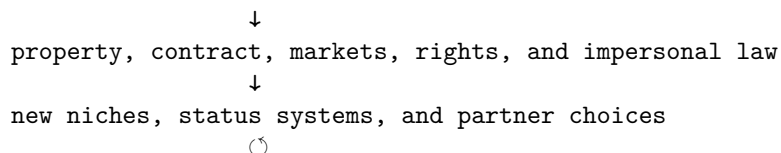
The strong prediction is:



A useful score must predict response beyond ancestry, demographics, institutions, and self-reported ideology. Failure to do so would count against the genetic-resonance hypothesis. Success would turn genetics from a distal story into an instrument that makes risky prospective predictions.

5. The European individualism-shift hypothesis The historical hypothesis is that Europe did not experience only a free-floating change of ideas. Kinship rules, Christianity, literacy, property, markets, cities, partner choice, migration, and institutions may have created sustained cultural selection for dispositions compatible with individual autonomy and impersonal cooperation. Enlightenment mythology then resonated especially strongly with the population produced by that history and further intensified the process.

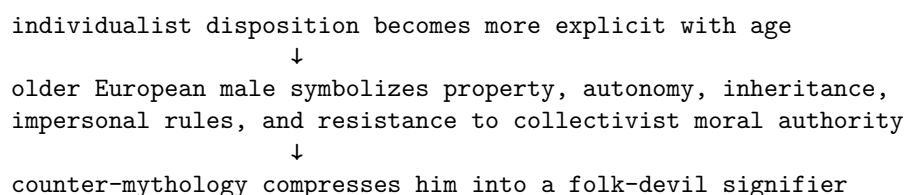




The strong version predicts detectable biological change over historical time; the weaker version predicts culturally amplified expression of a stable genetic distribution. Ancient DNA, modern genomic data, demographic history, and rival institutional explanations would be needed to distinguish them.

6. “Old White European Male” as a provocative corroboration heuristic The originating argument deliberately noticed a politically charged pattern. If older European men express an unusually strong individualist orientation—because of population history, sex-linked socialization, age amplification, or some combination—then their condensation into the hostile signifier “**Old White European Male**” may be read as a counter-mythology identifying the human carrier of the individual-sovereignty order it opposes.

Under that interpretation:



This is not confirmation by itself. The same label may encode perceived historical power, wealth, sex, ancestry, or institutional incumbency without tracking a genetic disposition. Its value is as a discriminating hypothesis: does hostility follow demonstrated individualist commitments more closely than age, sex, ancestry, wealth, or office considered separately?

7. Punctuality and assortative niche selection The punctuality example is intentionally mundane. A dispositional preference for temporal regularity encounters a mythology that calls punctuality respect, reliability, or honour. Schools and workplaces reward it. People choose friends, occupations, and partners who share it, while chronic unpunctuality becomes a real relationship cost. Cultural mythology has now altered social and potentially reproductive assortment.

No punctuality gene or score is presumed. The example shows what evidence would be required to move from cultural fit to gene–culture feedback: stable heritability, predictable recipient response, assortative partnering, and downstream differences in migration, status, fertility, or reproduction.

8. Producer and egalitarian-guardian clusters The labels **producer** and **guardian** borrow loosely from the differentiated social functions in *Plato’s Republic*, but the model is not Plato’s class order, psychology, or theory of rule. **Egalitarian guardian** and the proposed genetic-cluster hypothesis are new formulations in this synthesis. The strong hypothesis is that producer-like and egalitarian-guardian-like configurations may form partially stable and heritable clusters with different mythology preferences.

Proposed configuration	Expected resonant mythology
Producer-like	Contribution, proportionality, property, personal domain, impersonal accounting, maintenance
Egalitarian-guardian-like	Care, vulnerability, anti-dominance, solidarity, protection, deservingness attached to the guardian role

The hypothesis fails if the clusters cannot be measured reliably, do not replicate, prove wholly situational, or do not predict differential mythology response. If twin, genomic, latent-profile, and randomized-receptivity studies converge, the model gains credibility and practical value.

9. Close-kin marriage as reproductive and mythological network design The first-cousin-marriage hypothesis is the most concrete bridge between genetics and social radius. Marriage rules simultaneously decide who reproduces with whom, which families exchange obligations, and which mythologies repeatedly enter one another's households. The primary research by [Jonathan Schulz](#), [Duman Bahrami-Rad](#), [Jonathan Beauchamp](#), and [Joseph Henrich](#) links Western Church exposure, weakened intensive kinship, and psychological variation; the complete genetic-selection extension remains open.

The strong proposed sequence is:

```

close-kin marriage prohibited across generations
      ↓
reproductive, social, and mythological bridges cross clan boundaries
      ↓
exclusive clan coupling weakens and non-kin institutions expand
      ↓
impersonal trust and individualist civic mythology become more resonant
      ↓
new status, partner-choice, migration, and fertility patterns
      ↓
possible change in later dispositional distributions

```

These nine examples form a hypothesis ladder. Adoption and twin designs establish patterns of variance and developmental amplification. Cultural and kinship research identifies plausible mechanisms. Individualism scores, European genetic change, and producer-guardian clusters remain prospective tests. The framework becomes scientific by exposing the ladder, not by hiding its upper rungs because they have not yet been climbed.

11. Population diagnosis and mythology families

A constructor begins by studying the society rather than by polishing a message in isolation.

Population diagnosis asks:

- Which mythologies already organize the field?
- Which moral taste buds and motives do they activate?
- Which causal stories feel self-evident?
- Which identities and authorities possess trust?
- Which institutions embody the current order?
- Which historical wounds, triumphs, humiliations, and obligations remain alive?
- Which real coordination problems require a shared response?
- Which groups can still translate one another's moral language?
- Which proposed practices fit or violate the population's dispositions?

Moral reframing research supplies one limited empirical example of recipient fit. [Matthew Feinberg and Robb Willer](#) found that environmental appeals framed through purity reduced an ideological attitude gap in their experiments. Mythology construction generalizes the design question beyond single messages: how can the same higher-order project be expressed through several morally intelligible variants without becoming incoherent or deceptive?

A heterogeneous society will rarely be coordinated by one perfectly uniform story. It may require a **mythology family**:

```

shared second-order identity and goal
├── care-and-protection variant
├── proportionality-and-contribution variant
├── loyalty-and-continuity variant
├── liberty-and-personal-domain variant
└── sanctity-and-stewardship variant

```

The variants must converge on compatible practices. Reframing becomes dishonest when different groups are promised mutually exclusive outcomes or when the shared term hides an operational contradiction.

The proposed **producer-guardian model** can serve as one test case. A producer-like audience may respond especially to contribution, proportionality, property, personal responsibility, impersonal accounting, and protection from encroachment. An egalitarian-guardian-like audience may respond especially to care, vulnerability, anti-dominance, solidarity, and protective status. These are ideal-typical configurations, not biologically pure human kinds. The

research hypothesis is that they may reflect partly stable and partly heritable clusters that predict differential mythology receptivity.

Their constructive relationship is complementarity:

producer → builds, supplies, maintains, and accounts

guardian → detects threats, protects, and mobilizes against domination

↓

viable society when both remain reality-coupled and mutually bounded

A settlement makes the complementarity concrete. Producers keep food, water, tools, and buildings available every day. Guardians train for fires, attacks, disasters, or abuses that may not occur for years. During a long calm, preparedness can look like privileged idleness; during an emergency, its option value becomes unmistakable. The reciprocal pathologies are equally visible: a guardian can preserve status by manufacturing threats, while a producer can treat every warning as unproductive overhead. The ideal types are useful when they reveal this functional tension rather than assigning permanent moral worth to social categories.

Their pathological relationship arises when each mythology redescribes the other's function as moral illegitimacy. This example belongs to recipient diagnosis and hypothesis testing; mythology construction itself is not restricted to this political typology.

Mythology grammar and construction

12. Topoi, plot, and articulation

A mythology requires both reusable interpretive units and a causal sequence.

A **topos** is a recurring commonplace, scene, or argument location: the corrupt ruler, the forgotten sacrifice, the innocent child, the cheated worker, the threatened home, the ungrateful beneficiary, the sacred inheritance, the stranger who proves worthy, the bureaucracy that cannot see the person, or the free rider who endangers cooperation. The term is borrowed from [Aristotle's *Rhetoric* and *Topics*](#), where *topoi* are "places" or headings from which arguments can be found. Its use here is broader and less technical: it includes culturally recurring scenes and moral commonplaces, not only Aristotelian argument forms.

A **plot** or **mythos** organizes such elements through time. The word *mythos* is borrowed from [Aristotle's *Poetics*](#), where it refers to the organization of action in a plot. Here it is extended beyond drama to a society's causal-historical sequence:

original condition

↓

loss, violation, discovery, or opportunity

↓

allocation of causal and moral roles

↓

trial, struggle, sacrifice, or construction

↓

restoration, transformation, tragedy, or renewal

Topoi permit rapid recognition. Plot supplies direction and expectation. A mythology composed only of topoi produces disconnected emotional triggers. A mythology composed only of plot may remain too abstract to classify ordinary experience.

[Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe's account of articulation and hegemony](#) is useful here. Dispersed grievances or identities can be linked through an **equivalential chain**, divided from an antagonist, and represented through a partially empty common signifier. Mythology construction borrows these operations without adopting their complete political programme or treating all social unity as nothing but discursive articulation.

An equivalential chain may assemble different experiences under one term:

unpaid work

+ arbitrary authority

+ blocked mobility

+ public humiliation

↓ articulated as
"loss of dignity"

The common signifier gives the experiences a shared political or moral identity. Its compression is powerful because it reduces coordination costs. It is dangerous because the term can obscure differences in cause, scale, evidence, and remedy.

Construction therefore requires two opposite capacities:

- enough compression for recognition and collective action;
- enough differentiation to prevent a useful ideal type from becoming what [Stanley Cohen](#) called a **folk devil**: a publicly condensed and demonized carrier of social threat.

13. Causal stories

[Deborah Stone's "Causal Stories and the Formation of Policy Agendas"](#) explains how conditions become actionable problems through causal classification. Her fourfold scheme distinguishes whether action is guided or unguided and whether consequences are intended or unintended.

Causal story	Basic classification	Characteristic response
Accidental	Unguided action, unintended result	Relief, repair, preparation, resilience
Mechanical	Unguided mechanism, predictable result	Regulation, redesign, maintenance, dismantling
Inadvertent	Guided action, unintended result	Correction, constraint, forgiveness, restitution
Intentional	Guided action, intended result	Blame, punishment, resistance, deterrence

Causal stories do political and moral work because they allocate:

- agency;
- intention;
- responsibility;
- victimhood;
- preventability;
- competence;
- jurisdiction;
- remedy.

The same observable condition can be narrated as fate, accident, negligence, systemic mechanism, hostile design, or unintended consequence. Each story activates different moral taste buds and permissions.

Imagine that a bridge collapses. If an unprecedented lightning strike is presented as the cause, the likely response is rescue and preparation. If routine corrosion predictably weakened the structure, redesign and maintenance become central. If inspectors knowingly ignored warning signs without intending a collapse, negligence and restitution enter the scene. If someone planted explosives, punishment and security become salient. The rubble is the same; the assigned agency, intention, responsibility, and remedy are not. Evidence must decide among the stories rather than moral attraction deciding what counts as evidence.

Stone's contribution is therefore a central component of mythology grammar but not the whole theory. It explains how a mythology turns a condition into a problem with responsible actors and available remedies. It does not by itself explain recipient resonance, genetic variation, psychological gradient, institutional reproduction, or social coupling range.

14. Perception–Context–Permission

The proposed **Perception–Context–Permission** sequence, abbreviated **PCP**, describes how a mythology routes interpretation into action.

PERCEPTION

What kind of event, person, or condition is this?

↓

CONTEXT

What caused it, what history surrounds it, who occupies which role, and which moral dimensions are active?

↓

PERMISSION

What may, must, or must not now be done?

A mythology rarely needs to issue a naked command. If it successfully classifies perception and supplies context, the action can appear self-evidently required.

Consider four different classifications of the same loss:

misfortune	→ help and insure
negligence	→ correct and compensate
exploitation	→ resist and sanction
earned result	→ accept and learn

The moral disagreement may occur before the explicit value judgment. Two populations can endorse care, justice, and freedom yet prescribe opposite actions because they have placed the event inside different causal stories.

The PCP audit therefore asks:

1. What has been made perceptually salient?
2. What has been excluded from the scene?
3. Which causal story supplies context?
4. Which roles and intentions are assigned?
5. Which moral response is activated?
6. Which action now appears permissible or obligatory?
7. What competing classification fits the evidence?

15. Identity, role, symbol, and permission

Mythologies do not merely explain. They recruit.

An **identity offer** answers:

Who can I become inside this world?

A **role offer** answers:

What can someone like me concretely do?

Identity without role can produce expressive affiliation without capability. Role without identity can feel like arbitrary labour. Durable mythology joins them:

identity: "we are stewards"
+
role: inspect, maintain, teach, repair, and hand forward
↓
repeated practice confirms identity

Important role classes include:

- learner and apprentice;
- builder and producer;
- maintainer and steward;
- guardian and witness;
- parent and ancestor;
- judge and mediator;
- discoverer and truth-teller;
- penitent and repairer;
- teacher and transmitter.

The antagonist role requires special care. A mythology can identify a real obstacle, incentive, institution, practice, or perpetrator. It can also compress many heterogeneous people into a morally licensed enemy. The diagnostic

difference is whether responsibility remains precise, evidence-sensitive, answerable, and limited to demonstrable conduct.

Jacques Lacan's **master signifier**, later adapted in Laclau's political theory, supplies the model for a compact signifier that organizes a wider symbolic field. Mythology construction uses the expression more operationally: a flag, word, saint, martyr, monument, uniform, ritual object, anthem, or remembered event can activate an entire field of classification. This design use is therefore Lacanian-inspired, not identical to Lacan's formal place for S1 in the discourse of the master.

Some such tokens become **ideological conformity signals**: their performance, absence, refusal, or substitution makes a person's relation to the installed program publicly legible and enables monitoring, apparent consensus, recruitment, exclusion, or sanctions. The same token can become a **targeting signal** when its nonperformance exposes a sanctionable outsider; imposed markers and attributed labels can make target status legible without requiring refusal. The authoritative definitions, enforcement–exclusion duality, propagation and enforcement forms, jealousy axis, Andrick bridge, Stanton mapping, and worked examples remain together in *Culture Mechanics*. Mythology construction draws only the design warning: a constructor must inspect whether an intended symbol supports voluntary practice or creates a moralized loyalty test and an expanding claim to jurisdiction.

The **sacred-value** literature developed through Jonathan Baron and Mark Spranca's **protected values**, Philip Tetlock and colleagues' **sacred-value-protection model**, and Jeremy Ginges, Scott Atran, Douglas Medin, and Khalil Shikaki's **research on sacred political conflict**. A sacred object in the present framework defines what must not be casually traded away. This use broadens experimental "sacred values" to include symbols, practices, institutions, places, and relationships. Sacredness can protect dignity, truth, family, law, nature, or peace from opportunistic calculation. It can also block necessary comparison and correction. Construction therefore asks both:

- What must this mythology hold sacred to remain coherent?
- What happens when sacredness prevents the mythology from seeing reality or acknowledging another sacred claim?

16. Participatory discovery and co-authorship

The recipient should not be treated as an empty processor waiting for installation. Listening is part of construction.

Participatory discovery elicits:

- the recipient's own stories and moral vocabulary;
- experiences that do not fit the dominant mythology;
- ambivalence and unresolved contradiction;
- existing role models and admired practices;
- feared losses and desired futures;
- words that carry trust or contamination;
- the costs that would make adoption impossible.

The field experiments reported by Joshua Kalla and David Broockman found that nonjudgmental narrative exchange produced durable attitude change in their studied contexts, whereas closely related conversations without that exchange did not produce detectable effects. The result does not prove a universal mythology-construction method, but it supports **perspective-getting** and self-generated interpretation as promising mechanisms.

Edward Deci and Richard Ryan's **Self-Determination Theory** proposes that autonomy, competence, and relatedness support more integrated motivation. Research summarized in their account indicates that meaningful rationale, acknowledgement of difficulty or feeling, and choice can help people internalize otherwise uninteresting behaviour.

The constructive sequence is therefore:

```
recognition and respectful listening
      ↓
recipient articulates experience and conflict
      ↓
new mythology supplies a possible interpretation and role
      ↓
recipient tests, modifies, and voluntarily endorses it
      ↓
enactment produces competence and further evidence
```

Co-authorship does not mean telling every recipient whatever they want to hear. It means permitting the recipient to understand the operation, judge its reasons, and translate it into lived commitment. A mythology that can survive only through concealment has failed the agency test.

17. Institutional embodiment, activation, and transmission

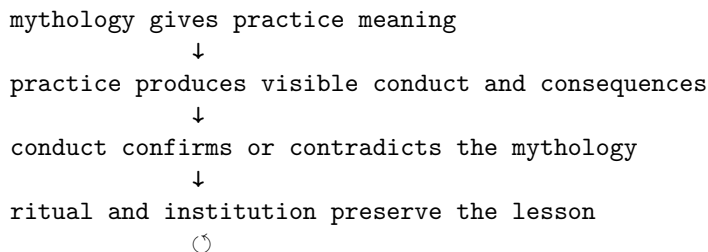
A mythology becomes culture when the surrounding system repeatedly tells the same story through conduct.

[Edgar Schein's work on organizational culture](#) identifies mechanisms through which leaders embed assumptions: what they attend to and measure, how they respond to crises, how they allocate resources and status, whom they recruit or remove, and what they model and teach. Mythology construction generalizes this insight beyond formal organizations.

Institutional embodiments include:

- calendars that organize collective time;
- rites of passage and remembrance;
- promotion and recognition systems;
- selection into trusted roles;
- legal procedures and appeal routes;
- schools and apprenticeship;
- architecture and public space;
- property and stewardship arrangements;
- professional protocols;
- sanctions and restitution;
- records, archives, and public memory;
- recurring service, maintenance, or protection duties.

Embodiment creates feedback:



Activation occurs when an event resembles an established pattern and calls the installed mythology into action. A crisis, anniversary, violation, victory, death, threat, or opportunity can rapidly transform a latent repertoire into synchronized judgment.

Transmission travels through more than mass media. Important paths include:

- parents and kin;
- peers and local exemplars;
- teachers, clergy, experts, and prestigious models;
- professional formation;
- stories attached to objects and places;
- institutional routines;
- entertainment and art;
- law, reward, and punishment;
- algorithmic visibility;
- imitation of visibly successful communities.

Transmission is strongest when speech, practice, reward, and consequence converge. A mythology of honesty taught by institutions that reward strategic lying constructs cynicism rather than honesty.

Psychological gradient and drive direction

18. Psychological gradients

Resonance explains why a person enters a mythology. It does not explain what keeps the person moving or where the path leads.

A **psychological gradient** describes the local resistance and reward structure of an interpretive or behavioural path.

A path is **psychologically downhill** when it offers immediate or familiar rewards and when each repetition tends to make the next repetition easier. The reward may be pleasure, but it may also be certainty, innocence, recognition, belonging, anger, blame, catharsis, or escape from responsibility.

A path is **psychologically uphill** when it requires an encounter that the person would otherwise avoid:

- uncertainty;
- delayed gratification;
- truthful feedback;
- injury to self-image;
- responsibility and reciprocity;
- disciplined repetition;
- unglamorous maintenance;
- risk of failure;
- resistance from physical or social reality.

Gradient is not identical to moral value. A constructive habit can become easy after formation. A destructive fanatic can endure extreme hardship. Rest and pleasure can replenish life; hardship can be pointless. Two separate questions must therefore be asked:

1. **Gradient:** How much immediate resistance does the path encounter?
2. **Direction:** What does repeated movement along the path cumulatively create or destroy?

19. Psychologically downhill and Lacanian death-drive mythologies

The elementary downhill mechanism uses **death-drive in Jacques Lacan's sense**, together with his vocabulary of **desire, demand, jouissance, repetition, and drive**. The principal sources are *The Seminar, Book XI: The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis* and "**Position of the Unconscious**" in *Écrits*. Freud remains the historical precursor, but the operative concept here is Lacan's reworking of the death-drive.

In this usage, death-drive is not a biological instinct that simply seeks literal death, nor is it synonymous with aggression. It names the excessive and repetitive aspect of drive: the circuit returns around its impasse, satisfaction attaches to the circuit itself, and repetition persists beyond the pleasure or stated goal it was supposed to serve. Lacan's compressed formulation is that "every drive is virtually a death drive." A death-drive mythology accordingly reproduces itself through the failure, grievance, demand, transgression, or destructive jouissance it repeatedly generates.

The exact mythology-construction sequence below is a cultural application of that Lacanian structure rather than a clinical formula stated by Lacan. In particular, the contrast between open desire and renewable demand is an operational model of mythological capture.

Open-ended desire can sustain exploration, vocation, relationship, creation, and movement toward an object that is never fully reducible to possession. A mythology can capture that openness by naming one supposedly final object:

```
open and mobile desire
    ↓
mythology names the missing object
    ↓
"obtain X and the lack will close"
    ↓
desire becomes a demand

The demand creates a renewable loop:

demand fulfilled
    ↓
```

brief satisfaction
↓
disappointment or boredom
↓
next demand

demand frustrated
↓
grievance and blame
↓
intensified demand

In both branches, failure of the promise can reproduce the mythology. The object changes while demanding, accusing, anticipating, and repeating become the stable activity.

This is the **death-drive turn** in the present framework:

Repetition no longer serves a destination; repetition becomes the destination.

The participant may receive jouissance from:

- demanding and accusing;
- experiencing betrayal;
- sharing indignation;
- identifying an inexhaustible enemy;
- receiving moral recognition for frustration;
- punishing a supposed obstacle;
- anticipating a completion that must never quite arrive;
- reenacting a familiar wound.

Downhill does not mean cheerful. A painful state can be downhill when it has become familiar, identity-confirming, socially rewarded, and easier than change.

The psychological attractor basin Repeated reward reshapes the landscape:

easy entry
↓
immediate affective or social reward
↓
habit and identity
↓
social reinforcement
↓
loss of alternative skills and relationships
↓
higher cost of exit
↓
deeper repetition

The mythology becomes a psychological potential well. A moment of doubt or insight may move the person temporarily, but old relationships, rewards, fears, and routines pull the person back.

Related downhill mechanisms Catharsis without transformation

anger → discharge → immediate relief → no durable creation

Recognition without production

The image of contribution earns status while difficult production, maintenance, or learning is avoided.

display → recognition → repeat display

Interpassivity

Robert Pfaller's **interpassivity**, developed from a Lacanian line of thought also associated with Slavoj Žižek, means delegated consumption or enjoyment: another person, machine, or ritual enjoys in one's place. The present framework borrows that mechanism but extends it to delegated moral and political performance: another person, institution, avatar, ritual, or post acts, believes, mourns, or rebels on the participant's behalf. This broader use should not be mistaken for Pfaller's complete theory.

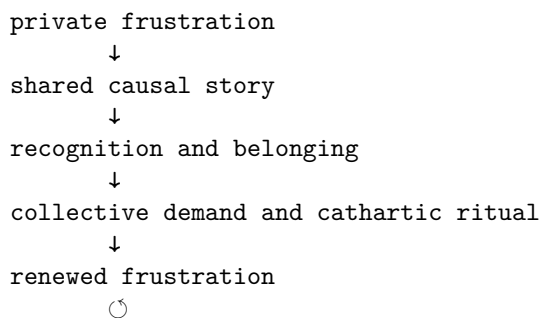
Paramorality

The term is borrowed from Andrew M. Łobaczewski's *Political Ponerology*, where *paramoralism* names morally suggestive language that serves pathological or deceptive ends. Łobaczewski's wider theory is controversial and is not adopted here. **Paramorality** is used more narrowly for an observable semantic operation: aggression, envy, irresponsibility, or vandalism is reclassified as care, justice, liberation, authenticity, or resistance. The drive receives gratification while the bigOther supplies moral approval.

Effort concealment

Stories display achievement while omitting training, repetition, failure, compromise, and maintenance. Recipients then experience effort shock when reality refuses the promised ease.

Collective downhillness



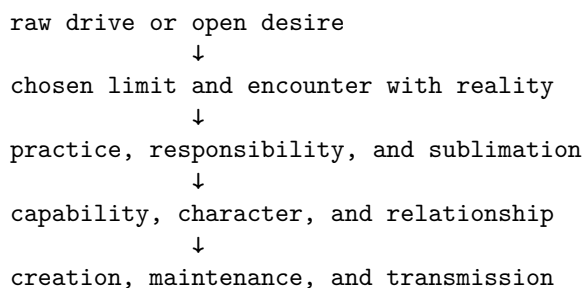
The group converts a private symptom basin into a distributed cultural attractor.

20. Psychologically uphill and Lacanian life-drive mythologies

Life-drive is likewise used in a Lacanian sense. In *Seminar XI*, Lacan treats the distinction between life-drive and death-drive as two aspects manifested by drive, not as two independently operating substances or a simple opposition between biological survival and biological death. The two aspects remain structurally entangled: the same drive can bind, create, and sustain a form while also acquiring a repetitive, excessive, or self-consuming circuit.

At the cultural level, a **life-drive mythology** organizes drive through symbols, limits, practices, relationships, and sublimations toward the building, binding, repair, reproduction, and transmission of life-supporting forms. This constructive cultural criterion is the present framework's operationalization of the Lacanian life-drive aspect; it should not be mistaken for a claim that whatever preserves biological life is therefore life-driven.

Its characteristic movement is:



Life-drive outcomes include:

- bodily and psychological health;
- skill and craftsmanship;
- truthful knowledge;
- trustworthy relationship;
- family and care across generations;

- maintained infrastructure;
- productive enterprise;
- ecological stewardship;
- institutions capable of learning;
- protection without predation;
- a world made more inhabitable for successors.

The uphill path can hurt locally because it exposes limitation, dependency, ignorance, and failure. It remains life-directed when the difficulty creates capabilities and relationships that expand later possibility.

A life-drive mythology gives difficulty an intelligible place. It can make:

- restraint honourable rather than humiliating;
- truthful correction a mark of integrity;
- patience part of mastery;
- maintenance visible as stewardship;
- contribution a source of justified pride;
- protection a disciplined duty rather than licensed aggression;
- posterity more meaningful than immediate consumption.

21. Sublimation and moral formation

Sublimation is the central transformation between raw drive and civilizational capability. The concept comes from [Sigmund Freud's psychoanalytic account of civilization and drive transformation](#), although its use here is extended from individual psychodynamics into an institutional theory of moral formation.

Sublimation neither denies nor simply releases the original drive. It gives the energy another form:

Raw energy or impulse	Possible sublimated form
Aggression	Courage, protection, disciplined competition
Status desire	Excellence, achievement, honourable service
Self-interest	Reciprocity, contract, trade, and accountable enterprise
Curiosity	Science, scholarship, exploration, and craft
Sexual and possessive energy	Courtship, fidelity, family formation, and generative care
Desire for control	Planning, stewardship, administration, and lawful authority
Sensitivity to insult	Courtesy, tact, self-command, and conflict resolution
Group loyalty	Citizenship, service, and responsibility for a common world
Restlessness	Initiative, invention, and disciplined adventure

The **psychological-alchemy analogy** captures the transformation: sublimation attempts to turn inner “lead” into social “gold.” The aggression, ambition, curiosity, sexuality, or sensitivity is not imagined away. Its energy is refined through limits, symbols, practice, and responsibility until it can perform work that raw discharge could not.

Civilization depends upon a **bundle of shared sublimations**:

courtesy
+ honesty
+ temporal discipline
+ reciprocity
+ delayed gratification
+ evidential standards
+ lawful conflict resolution
+ responsibility

civilizational character

Politeness formulas, turn-taking, punctuality, promise-keeping, due process, evidence, citation, protocol, and professional discipline can be understood as institutionalized sublimations. They store ways of transforming drives so that strangers can cooperate without a perfect system or constant supervision.

Formal institutions cannot substitute completely for character. Courts require people willing to tell unwelcome truths. Science requires investigators capable of relinquishing favoured claims. Contracts require some fidelity beyond immediate advantage. Democracy requires losers who remain members of the constitutional community.

Thomas Sowell's *A Conflict of Visions* captures the constrained-vision account with the deliberately sharp image that each new generation arrives as an invasion of civilization by "little barbarians" who must be civilized before it is too late. The point is not contempt for children. It is that no newborn inherits courtesy, self-command, truthfulness, punctuality, reciprocity, or work discipline in finished cultural form. Each generation must be initiated into the braid through largely unarticulated example, correction, practice, and expectation. Where formation does not take, a formally perfect system cannot compensate indefinitely for the missing character of its participants.

The originating formulation carries a harder consequence: people in whom this civilizing process does not take—because the formation was weak, because the surrounding mythology rewarded the opposite, or because the person resisted it—can become sources of antisocial conduct, of which crime is only one form. Mythology construction therefore concerns not decorative cultural refinement but the intergenerational production of adults capable of sustaining a cooperative civilization.

The formative sequence is:

```
raw drive
  ↓
external boundary and example
  ↓
repeated practice
  ↓
habituation
  ↓
sublimation
  ↓
internalized character
  ↓
voluntary search for meaningful difficulty
```

22. Mythology as the education of psychological taste

The contrast between a very sweet drink and acquired tastes such as olives or dry wine supplies a developmental analogy.

Psychological childhood prefers intense, immediate, uncomplicated sweetness:

- gratification without delay;
- moral importance without achievement;
- certainty without inquiry;
- recognition without production;
- benefits without reciprocal cost;
- redemption without transformation;
- an enemy who explains every frustration.

Psychological adulthood learns to value complexity, restraint, responsibility, mastery, truth, and creation. Here adulthood names a developmental achievement rather than chronological age.

A civilizational mythology must therefore perform two operations:

```
meet the recipient where existing desire can recognize an entry
  ↓
lead that desire toward a more mature and generative form
```

Mythology construction is not merely taste matching. It is also taste education.

A mythology that maximizes present resonance without considering formation resembles a market that sells children the sweetest available drink. It can win immediate adoption while reducing the capacity to appreciate demanding goods. A formative mythology begins with available motives but attaches honour, belonging, and status to disciplines that expand the person.

If unlimited sweetness is supplied for long enough, the problem deepens: ordinary reality begins to taste intolerably bitter. Work, compromise, waiting, correction, and reciprocity then feel not merely difficult but like illegitimate deprivations. Taste education therefore changes both what is desired and what kinds of frustration can be borne without retreating into a downhill story.

Herbert Marcuse's *Eros and Civilization* represents one important dispute over sublimation. Marcuse distinguishes repression necessary to association from historically contingent "surplus-repression" and imagines less repressive sublimation. The present framework asks whether practices classified as surplus-repression may contain tacit civilizational knowledge and whether their removal produces liberation, constructive resublimation, or psychologically downhill desublimation. Marcuse is an illustrative case, not the foundation of the uphill/downhill distinction.

Marcuse as a linguistic dark artist The originating judgment of this framework is sharper. Read operationally, Marcuse's liberation tends toward **liberation from civilization**: liberation from arts, habits, work discipline, sexual restraint, courtesy, authority, and moral formation insofar as these are reclassified as repressive sublimations. Marcuse understands his project as liberation of civilization from historically unnecessary domination. The present framework's verdict is that the attempted separation of necessary repression from "surplus-repression" can dismantle the inherited bundle of sublimations on which mature freedom depends.

```
inherited restraint and discipline
    ↓ Marcusean classification
surplus-repression serving domination
    ↓
liberation authorizes removal of the restraint
    ↓ possible result
immediate gratification and desublimation
    ↓
weaker character, capability, and institutional maintenance
```

Marcuse is also treated here as a master practitioner of linguistic dark arts. The reading rule is not that every word has a mechanically inverted dictionary meaning. It is that an attractive moral noun may retain its emotional halo while a qualifier reverses the operation performed in its name.

His essay "**Repressive Tolerance**" supplies an unusually clear example. Ordinary tolerance permits opposed views to exist and compete. Marcuse reclassifies that general tolerance as repressive, then explicitly defines **liberating tolerance** asymmetrically: intolerance toward movements of the Right and tolerance toward movements of the Left. The vocabulary of tolerance remains; the operational payload includes withdrawal of tolerance from selected speech, assembly, opinion, and movements.

```
ordinary moral meaning
tolerance → permit opposed views
    ↓ ideological qualification
general tolerance → "repressive tolerance"
    ↓ moral inversion
tolerance now reproduces oppression
    ↓ action permission
selective intolerance becomes justified
    ↓ semantic relabelling
selective intolerance → "liberating tolerance"
```

This yields the **qualified-concept alarm**:

When an otherwise clear and morally attractive concept receives an ideological qualifier, stop reading fluently. Translate the qualified expression into concrete actors, actions, permissions, and prohibitions.

The audit asks:

1. What did the unqualified word ordinarily mean?
2. Which cases has the qualifier removed from that meaning?
3. Which contrary operations has it introduced?
4. Who decides when the qualifier applies?
5. Is the revised rule symmetrical between allies and opponents?
6. What may now be done that the ordinary concept would have forbidden?

The governing distinction is:

SEMANTIC WRAPPER

tolerance, liberation, autonomy, humanity

↓ inspect

OPERATIONAL PAYLOAD

who may speak, who must yield, who decides,
which restraint is dismantled, and who may be suppressed

This case matters to mythology construction because the qualifier rewrites PCP:

PERCEPTION existing tolerance is not genuine tolerance

CONTEXT the public sphere is already an instrument of repression

PERMISSION suppressing selected views becomes an act of liberation

The dark art does not merely lie about a fact. It captures a prestigious word, reverses its permissions, and makes the reversal feel like fidelity to the original virtue.

23. Replicative success versus flourishing

A mythology can be fit as a replicator and destructive for its carriers.

high resonance

+ immediate psychological reward

+ strong group enforcement

+ self-sealing causal story

rapid cultural replication

rapid cultural replication

does not imply

truth, agency, capability, prosperity, or survival

Mythology construction therefore distinguishes at least three success criteria:

1. **Replicative success:** Does the mythology spread and persist?
2. **Carrier success:** Do participants become more capable of flourishing, relationship, creation, and reality contact?
3. **System success:** Does the society maintain cooperation, correction, material viability, and intergenerational continuity?

A death-drive mythology may optimize the first while consuming the second and third. A constructive mythology must become culturally viable without sacrificing the people and institutions that carry it.

The governing contrast is:

gratification that consumes the future

versus

disciplined transformation that creates a future

Social coupling, scale, and collective agency

24. Coupling strength and coupling radius

A mythology can resonate intensely and still fail to support a society. Population-scale construction must consider not only the strength of a bond but the distance across which it remains effective.

The physical analogy uses two parameters:

- **coupling amplitude:** how strong obligation, trust, identification, and emotional synchronization are at close range;
- **coupling radius:** how far those bonds extend across kinship, locality, class, religion, profession, and subculture.

clan-like order

high local amplitude + short radius

thick trust within, steep decay beyond

civic order
lower peak amplitude + long radius
thinner but generalized trust among strangers

The analogy is functional, not a claim that social bonds obey a literal physical force law.

Strong short-range coupling can sustain extraordinary sacrifice and mutual aid. It can also make impartial law, public office, and cooperation with outsiders difficult. Wider coupling supports markets, cities, professions, universal religions, federations, and citizenship, but may feel emotionally thinner and require institutional reinforcement.

At short range, the distinction can be felt in an ordinary emergency. A person may be able to summon several relatives at midnight with no written agreement while feeling little duty toward an unknown neighbour. A civic order asks for something less intimate but more extensive: predictable restraint, assistance, truthful dealing, and respect for common rules among millions of people who will never become kin. The first bond is thick and concentrated; the second is thinner but travels farther.

Mythology participates in this topology. Clan-centred mythology emphasizes ancestry, blood, honour, concrete loyalty, and remembered reciprocal obligation. Wide-net mythology emphasizes shared law, office, contract, universal dignity, citizenship, profession, or stewardship of a common world.

A constructor must therefore ask:

- At what social radius must cooperation occur?
- Which inherited bonds will support it?
- Which bonds will experience it as betrayal?
- Can a wider identity incorporate local loyalty without abolishing it?
- Does the mythology create bridges or only intensify one cluster?

25. Marriage rules as gene–culture coupling mechanisms

Marriage rules—including rules permitting, preferring, or forbidding first-cousin and other close-kin marriage—are unusually powerful culture strategies because they alter three networks simultaneously.

Reproductive network Marriage affects who reproduces with whom, influencing relatedness, gene flow, population structure, and long-term selection pressures.

Social network Marriage creates alliances, obligations, inheritance paths, and recurring cooperation between families. Endogamy concentrates these connections; exogamy distributes them.

Mythological network Marriage determines which households repeatedly exchange stories, rituals, authorities, customs, moral concepts, and identities.

The proposed **marriage-mediated coupling-range hypothesis** is:

prohibition of close-kin marriage
↓
partners sought beyond the immediate clan
↓
gene flow and alliances cross clan boundaries
↓
exclusive kinship coupling weakens
↓
social and mythological coupling reaches farther
↓
non-kin institutions become more useful and intelligible
↓
abstract civic identity becomes more plausible

One out-marriage creates a single bridge between two family clusters. Repetition across households and generations turns isolated bridges into a mesh through which obligations, stories, practices, and genes travel. The point is not

that affection must become weaker in every individual marriage. It is that exclusive social closure around one dense kin cluster becomes harder to maintain when reproduction and alliance repeatedly cross its boundary.

The reverse hypothesis is:

preferred close-kin marriage
↓
reproductive and social relations remain concentrated
↓
dense genetically and socially interrelated clans
↓
strong local obligation and short-range trust
↓
mythologies circulate mainly within the clan
↓
first-order mechanical solidarity remains dominant

[Jonathan Schulz](#), [Duman Bahrami-Rad](#), [Jonathan Beauchamp](#), and [Joseph Henrich](#) connect Western Church exposure, weakened intensive kinship, and global psychological variation. Their work supplies important prior evidence for investigating this mechanism; it does not by itself settle every causal step, genetic consequence, or application proposed here.

The genetics link is essential to the hypothesis. Marriage rules do not merely teach wider cooperation. Across generations they organize reproductive population structure while the resulting alliances alter cultural learning and institutional selection. They are therefore a direct gene–culture coupling mechanism.

26. First-order and lifted mechanical solidarity

[Émile Durkheim](#) uses **mechanical solidarity** for cohesion through likeness and a strong common consciousness, and **organic solidarity** for cohesion through differentiated interdependence.

The proposed term **first-order mechanical solidarity** names solidarity in which members share concrete rules and answers. **Lifted mechanical solidarity** names solidarity in which they share the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers:

fixed meta-rules M + current knowledge or inputs K_t + situation $C \rightarrow$ binding first-order output $R_t(C)$

Fixed means operatively installed and binding, not eternal. Generator and outputs are parts of one operative weave. A large body of detailed rules followed as self-compulsorily proper is strong evidence of predominantly first-order solidarity, but not its definition. A lifted order can also generate many detailed rules; its binding sameness lies in the generator. [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#) contains the concrete religious, anthropological, hygienic, legal, market, scientific, and procedural cases.

Lifting often permits people to reach different first-order answers while remaining members of one order. It may therefore support plural lives, division of labour, impersonal authority, and bounded jurisdictions. Those are important possible consequences of the generator architecture, not its definition. The mechanical element has not disappeared: participants are alike in treating the answer-generating rules as binding.

Under single-slot exclusivity, both forms can produce **full capture**: one operative weave completely occupies the local bigOther. First-order full capture governs through shared concrete answers. Lifted full capture governs through one shared answer generator. That generator may have universal jurisdiction and may produce plural first-order outputs and bounded authorities. Whether either capture is open and corrigible or closed and pathological is a separate axis.

This solidarity must be mythologically constructed and ritually renewed. A constitution printed on paper cannot by itself make losing an election non-existential, public office non-proprietary, or an opponent legitimate.

Authority migration across levels of solidarity The movement from first-order to lifted solidarity may also change **who may speak for the bond**. This is an authority-scaling hypothesis, not part of the order-level definition. First-order fields are predicted to concentrate more apologetic and polemical authority in embodied persons, whereas lifted fields can locate more of it in persistent offices and institutions represented by replaceable human beings. The lifted order does not eliminate persons; it can change the source and continuity of the authority they carry.

This migration does not move universal jurisdiction from a person into one all-powerful institution. The lifted meta-order is universal over the allocation and limitation of jurisdictions; courts, universities, parliaments, churches, professions, and public services represent and administer bounded parts of it. No one office thereby owns all interpretation, still less reality itself. A persistent institution can act across generations without receiving epistemic sovereignty.

This proposed migration also changes actor selection. A first-order field is predicted to select more through personal embodiment of its concrete answers; a lifted field can select through demonstrated competence within its procedures and offices. Both remain mixtures of disposition and collective recognition. Neither personal nor institutional authority becomes systemically operative through private declaration alone.

A pathological transition can combine the disadvantages of both forms: institutional power without impersonal procedure, or personal charisma concealed behind institutional language. The design question is therefore not simply whether persons or institutions act, but whether authority, selection, succession, and correction fit the scale and content of the solidarity being defended.

Lifting is consequently one form of successor mythology construction. It unbraids the finality of shared concrete answers and rebraids one shared generator that can produce, apply, and revise answers. The successor may govern universally and may retain old material as inputs or current outputs. It is not an exception to complete slot occupancy or to unbraid/rebraid replacement.

27. Democracy export as a resonance problem

Liberal democracy presupposes more than ballots and institutions. Its mythology includes:

- the autonomous citizen;
- equality before impersonal law;
- loyal opposition;
- peaceful transfer of power;
- freedom of conscience;
- the right of political losers to remain full members;
- public office as a temporary trust rather than clan property;
- abstract reciprocity among strangers.

A ballot box can be manufactured, shipped, and installed. **Loyal opposition cannot be shipped in the same crate.** The latter depends upon a formed expectation that losing office does not expel a person or group from the moral community, that public power is temporary, and that an opponent can remain legitimate while being wrong. Democracy export fails when the visible operation arrives without the state of character and shared mythology from which the operation makes sense.

The **democracy-export hypothesis** is:

Democratic institutions will remain fragile when the lifted civic mythology that makes them intelligible fails to resonate with the receiving population's dispositional distribution, inherited culture, kinship topology, and authority structure.

Under mismatch, imported forms can be assimilated into older solidarities:

election	→ census of clans or sects
party	→ patronage vehicle
public office	→ property of the victorious group
opposition	→ betrayal
electoral loss	→ existential dispossession
law	→ instrument of relational power

The visible operation has been transmitted, but the state from which the operation makes sense has not.

The stronger genetic version predicts that populations may differ partly in the distribution of polygenic dispositions supporting impersonal trust, individual autonomy, pluralism, non-kin cooperation, and tolerance of legitimate disagreement. This remains a direct research hypothesis, not a claim that a population is biologically incapable of democracy.

The genetic-hardware hypothesis The blunt originating formulation should not be hidden:

Some genetic hardware may not be made for lifted mechanical solidarity.

“Not made for” does not mean metaphysically incapable. It means that the historically formed distribution of dispositions in one population may make an abstract civic mythology run naturally, while another population must spend far more institutional and formative energy to maintain the same operation.

The relevant candidate hardware includes dispositions affecting:

- autonomy from kin and inherited authority;
- trust in strangers and impersonal procedure;
- willingness to separate office from family possession;
- tolerance of moral and religious pluralism;
- acceptance of abstract rather than face-to-face reciprocity;
- ability to lose power without treating loss as expulsion from the community;
- willingness to regard an opponent as wrong but legitimate.

The software analogy is exact enough to be useful. The democratic procedure is an operation; lifted solidarity is part of the state from which the operation makes sense; dispositional distributions are part of the hardware on which that cultural state must run.

same imported democratic operation

↓

hardware and mythology fit

→ loyal opposition, impersonal office, peaceful succession

hardware and mythology mismatch

→ clan census, patronage, winner-takes-all possession, existential defeat

The test is comparative and prospective. If measured dispositions or future polygenic scores predict which populations and individuals sustain lifted-solidarity practices under otherwise similar institutions, the hardware hypothesis gains support. If institutional history and current incentives exhaust the prediction, its genetic component loses support.

Institutional coadaptation may bridge the mismatch through federalism, communal autonomy, local self-government, power sharing, customary institutions, and gradual construction of an overarching civic mythology. Such arrangements coordinate existing solidarities while a wider one develops.

28. Coordination, synchronization, and the coupling thermostat

Collective agency does not require everyone to think, feel, or act identically.

Coordination arranges differentiated contributions toward a compatible result. **Synchronization** aligns timing, attention, feeling, or judgment. Some tasks require both; others become less intelligent when synchrony suppresses independence.

too little common meaning

→ fragmentation and inability to act together

too much synchronization

→ conformity, common-mode error, and loss of correction

viable coupling

→ sufficient shared meaning for cooperation

+ sufficient independence for perception and learning

The **coupling thermostat** is the mythology-construction problem of calibrating this balance.

Useful synchrony can provide:

- courage under danger;
- rapid emergency action;
- ritual solidarity;
- shared attention;
- confidence that others will perform complementary duties.

Excessive synchrony can produce:

- emotional escalation;
- identity fusion;
- suppression of minority perception;
- synchronized institutional error;
- inability to change course without collective humiliation.

A society-wide mythology should normally synchronize high-level identity and constitutional procedure more strongly than detailed empirical judgment. It should enable people to act together without requiring them to see every fact through one authorized lens.

29. Babelization and the destruction of collective agency

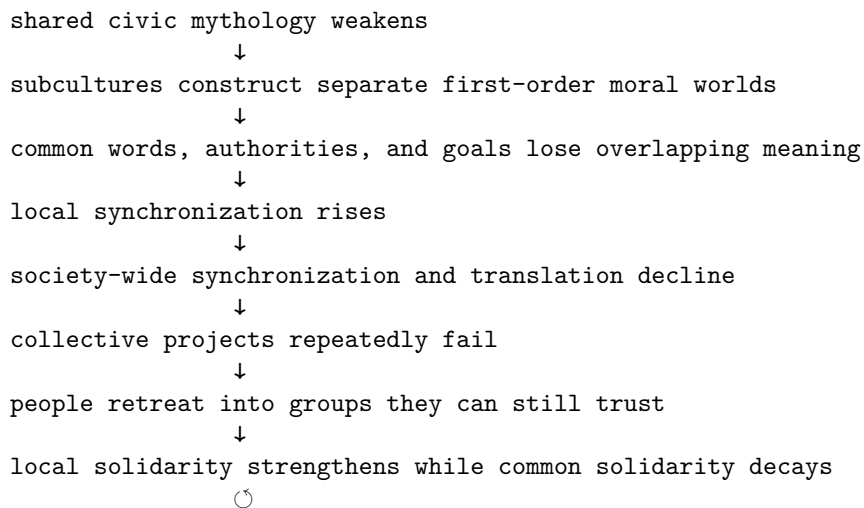
Babelization is the fragmentation of a shared symbolic language to the point that a society can no longer circulate common mythologies, recognize common purposes, or coordinate as a collective subject.

The [Tower of Babel story in Genesis 11](#) supplies the governing image. **Babelization** is an analogy and proposed technical extension, not a claim that the biblical text states the social theory developed here. “Language” here means more than mutually intelligible vocabulary. It includes shared:

- categories and distinctions;
- moral meanings;
- causal stories;
- historical memory;
- sacred symbols;
- standards and authorities;
- understandings of office, legitimacy, and common purpose.

A society can continue using the same words while their operative meanings diverge. *Justice, freedom, violence, equality, democracy, truth, and safety* may evoke incompatible worlds, agents, and permissions.

The Babelizing sequence is:



The result is not mere individualism. It is **local synchronization with global desynchronization**. Each subculture may possess a strong local bigOther, sacred history, victimology, enemy image, and epistemic authority. The society remains materially interdependent while becoming mythologically clan-like.

Babelization destroys collective agency when no actor can formulate a goal that remains intelligible and legitimate across the necessary population. Institutions cease to be common instruments and become prizes through which one subculture attempts to impose its mythology on the others.

An orchestra supplies a compact analogy. Every quartet may be internally synchronized and technically excellent, yet the orchestra cannot perform if each quartet follows a different score, tempo, and definition of the piece. Making each quartet louder and more internally unified worsens the whole. Society-wide agency similarly requires a shared second-order score—common procedures, sufficiently overlapping terms, and a recognizable common performance—without requiring every instrument to play the same notes.

Culture mixing as a Babel mechanism The originating claim is not merely that semantic fragmentation sometimes happens. It is that **culture mixing can destroy collective agency** when a previously shared mythology is fragmented faster than a new lifted mythology can integrate the incoming parts.

Suppose a society begins with substantial common language, memory, authority, and second-order solidarity. It then develops or imports many subcultures, each potentially organized by its own first-order mechanical solidarity:

```

one society-wide mythology
      ↓ rapid fragmentation or mixing without integration
many locally complete mythologies
      ↓
different sacred histories, authorities, victims, enemies,
causal stories, and meanings of common words
      ↓
local bigOthers grow stronger
      ↓
society-wide translation and synchronization collapse
      ↓
common projects stall and institutions become intergroup prizes
      ↓
retreat into clan-like groups

```

This is Tower-of-Babel-style culture destruction. People may still speak the same dictionary language, share streets, use the same infrastructure, and vote in the same elections. Yet they can no longer transmit a common mythology or formulate goals whose meaning survives passage between groups.

The framework therefore does not treat cultural mixing as automatically benign. The outcome depends upon the relative rates of two processes:

```

rate at which incompatible first-order mythologies multiply
                        versus
rate at which a credible shared second-order mythology integrates them

```

When integration wins, diversity can enlarge competence and perspective inside lifted solidarity. When fragmentation wins, mixture produces local synchronization and global paralysis. The humanly important question is not whether diversity sounds attractive in the abstract. It is whether the mixed society can still say “**we**,” mean sufficiently similar things by its central words, recognize common authorities and procedures, and act toward a common future.

Diversity is not identical to Babelization. First-order diversity is compatible with collective agency when groups retain:

- a shared second-order identity;
- overlapping meanings for central terms;
- trusted translation routes;
- common institutions recognized as legitimate;
- procedures through which political losers remain members;
- superordinate goals;
- sufficient intergroup contact to correct caricature.

The **Babel test** for a proposed mythology is therefore:

Does it build a bridge across groups required for common action, or does it merely make one local cluster more coherent and the society less interoperable?

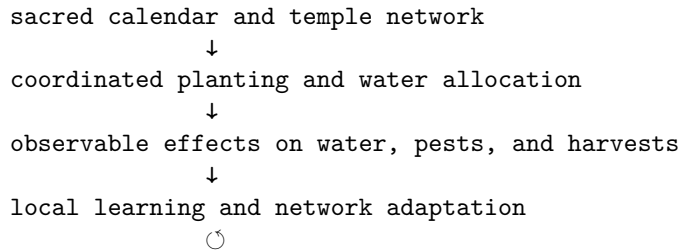
Reality coupling and adversarial mythology construction

30. Reality-coupled mythology

A **reality-coupled mythology** connects meaning and ritual to practices whose consequences provide continuing feedback.

The Balinese water-temple or **subak** system is an important positive case. [J. Stephen Lansing](#) and [James Kremer](#) describe networks in which temples, sacred obligations, farmer associations, irrigation, planting schedules, and pest control formed a complex adaptive system.

The mythology did not merely produce collective sentiment. It helped make adaptive cooperation meaningful, memorable, and enforceable:



The case suggests a strong design principle:

A constructive mythology should attach sacred meaning and social honour to practices whose adaptive value remains exposed to material feedback.

Reality coupling can take several forms:

- ecological consequence;
- prediction and measurement;
- craftsmanship and physical performance;
- voluntary participation and costly exit;
- comparison among institutions;
- reciprocal exchange;
- health and developmental outcomes;
- durable infrastructure;
- correction by people bearing consequences.

Reality coupling can be weak and delayed. Good culture strategies often work like compound interest: one honest exchange, maintained tool, punctual meeting, or fair procedure may show little immediate advantage, while cumulative effects become enormous. This delay gives emotionally dramatic but destructive mythologies an adversarial advantage.

31. Epistemic constitution and correction

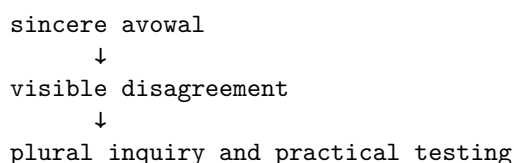
Mythology construction changes the very lens through which correction will later be interpreted. It must therefore design its own limits.

A reality-anchored mythology preserves:

- independent evidence routes;
- meaningful disagreement;
- memory of failed predictions and previous meanings;
- provenance and inspectable reasons;
- domain limits on authority;
- honourable correction and mind-changing;
- reversible experiments where possible;
- dignified exit;
- distinction between criticism of a claim and expulsion of a person.

In the framework-specific sense used here, the **epistemic constitution of lifted mechanical solidarity** is the society-wide arrangement that decides whether strangers can disagree, test claims, remember failure, and correct shared belief while remaining members of one civic order. This formulation is proposed here; it is not Durkheim's own term. Mythology construction can move that constitution toward a reality-anchored, truth-seeking order or toward a systemic-lying order.

Reality-anchored recursion:



↓
 encounter with reality
 ↓
 correction and revised practice
 ↻

Self-sealing recursion:

mythology authorizes the evidence
 ↓
 contradiction proves hostility or impurity
 ↓
 failure proves insufficient commitment
 ↓
 greater synchronization and punishment
 ↓
 less corrective information
 ↻

The central epistemic maxim is:

A mythology may organize society's encounter with reality; it may not receive the right to determine what reality is permitted to be.

An **adversarial linguistic audit** should inspect local operations involving assertion, omission, redefinition, framing, discussion corruption, enemy construction, moral attribution, agenda control, and policy coupling. The label is proposed in this synthesis; its component tests draw on established rhetoric, framing, propaganda analysis, and ordinary critical reasoning. Those operations should be examined in the mythology's own language as rigorously as in an opponent's.

Apologetic closure and polemical corrosion Apologetics and polemics each have a reality-coupled and a pathological form:

REALITY-COUPLED APOLOGETICS

preserve the braid → answer the strongest objection → repair error → retain justified trust

SELF-SEALING APOLOGETICS

preserve authority → reinterpret every objection as hostility → hide error → demand greater faith

REALITY-COUPLED POLEMICS

isolate a false binding → show evidence and consequence → preserve sound strands → enable replacement

CORROSIVE POLEMICS

compare reality with an undefined perfection → redescribe every limit as guilt → dissolve trust → evade the

The first pathology makes the installed mythology impossible to correct. The second makes any installed order impossible to justify because every real institution can be condemned for failing to instantiate an imaginary condition without scarcity, conflict, error, trade-off, or unintended consequence.

This is the framework's sharp critical diagnosis of one possible use of critique: **delegitimize a real order by holding it against an unspecified or impossible ideal, break people's faith in the order because it exists under the contingencies of reality, and leave the positive successor obscure until the incumbent has lost authority.** In that mode, cynicism acts like corrosive acid on the braid. It need not disprove each strand; it only has to make fidelity, gratitude, and ordinary confidence appear naïve or culpable.

That diagnosis must not be substituted for the historical self-description of the Frankfurt School. [Max Horkheimer's 1937 "Traditional and Critical Theory"](#) presents Critical Theory as an attempt to bring the social totality toward a rational form while remaining connected to empirical disciplines. The corrosive pattern described here is a **failure mode and polemical interpretation**, not a neutral dictionary definition of all Critical Theory. [Helen Pluckrose and James A. Lindsay's *Cynical Theories*](#) is relevant prior art for examining how the authors understand postmodern and activist theories to threaten science, reason, liberal ethics, and open debate. The **corrosive-acid metaphor** and its place in the one-slot replacement model are proposed here rather than attributed to them as a quotation.

A disciplined audit therefore asks both sides symmetrical questions:

- What exactly does the apologetic defence preserve, and what evidence would make it concede or repair a strand?
- What exactly does the polemic disprove: a factual claim, a causal binding, an authority claim, or merely the fact that the institution is imperfect?
- Does the critic specify the constraints under which any successor must operate?
- Which goods and sound strands will survive the unbraiding?
- Who bears responsibility for the vacancy, transition costs, and successor permissions created by the critique?

32. Downhill honey traps and dark artists

A destructive mythology constructor has an asymmetrical advantage. Immediate psychic rewards are easier to demonstrate than the slow returns of sublimation.

DOWNHILL MYTHOLOGY

resonance



instant certainty, innocence, belonging, status, blame, or catharsis



renewed demand and repetition



dependency, dissipated energy, and reduced capability

UPHILL MYTHOLOGY

resonance



chosen challenge and meaningful role



practice, sublimation, and reality feedback



competence, contribution, and accumulated social capital

A **downhill honey trap** is a mythology that uses an attractive immediate reward to draw recipients into a self-reinforcing path whose longer consequences reduce agency, maturation, or flourishing.

Its characteristic offers include:

- moral importance without earned capability;
- absolution from responsibility;
- an enemy who explains every failure;
- endless demands presented as final completion;
- aggression laundered as protection or justice;
- belonging conditional upon repeated outrage;
- interpassive action and symbolic consumption;
- liberation defined as release from formative restraint;
- immunity from correction through self-sealing causal stories.

Suicidal empathy and the egalitarian-guardian failure mode [Gad Saad](#) uses **suicidal empathy** for a care response that continues even when it works against the survival interests of the person or society extending it.

His provocative example is a reported street interview with a queer woman supporting “Free Palestine.” Asked whether she understood that people in the society she supported might kill her for her queer identity, she answered yes and maintained her support because they were still human beings deserving care.

The example isolates the directed logic proposed for the egalitarian guardian:

group classified as weak, vulnerable, or oppressed



care and anti-dominance machinery activates



hostility from the protected group is discounted

↓

reciprocity and self-protection lose moral priority

↓

continued solidarity becomes proof of moral purity

The key question is whether this is genuinely universal empathy. Would the same unconditional sentence be extended to people classified not as oppressed but as dominant, reactionary, or fascistic—for example, conservative Christian opponents of abortion? If care follows the oppressed classification rather than humanity as such, the mechanism is not simple universalism. It is a directed guardian programme whose if-then condition can override reciprocity.

The example does not establish that all queer support for Palestinian civilians has this structure. A person may oppose collective punishment, distinguish civilians from governments, or accept risk as a universal moral commitment. The anecdote belongs here because the reported answer displays the limiting case with unusual clarity: the guardian role treats withdrawal of care in response to mortal hostility as a betrayal of identity.

The hairworm and wood-cricket analogy Saad compares suicidal empathy to a wood cricket infected by a hairworm. The biological substrate of the analogy is real: experiments report that crickets infected by the nematomorph *Paragordius tricuspidatus* are more likely than uninfected crickets to enter water, where the aquatic adult worm can continue its life cycle. The exact sensory mechanism is more complicated than a parasite simply “telling” the cricket where water is. [Frédéric Thomas and colleagues](#) found altered behaviour leading infected insects toward the fatal transition.

Saad’s cultural analogy is:

foreign programme enters the host

↓

normal aversion and survival priorities are redirected

↓

the host performs conduct harmful to itself

↓

the programme completes its own reproductive cycle

Applied to mythology construction, the “parasite” is not a disliked population and the recipient is not literally an insect. The candidate parasite is a self-replicating mythological programme that captures care, status, guilt, or anti-dominance and uses the recipient’s own moral machinery to suppress self-preservation and correction.

The analogy earns its place because it distinguishes two success functions:

success of the host
 ≠
 success of the programme reproducing through the host

A mythology may spread precisely because it induces costly signalling, self-sacrifice, and immunity to disconfirming consequences. Calling the pattern parasitic is a strong causal claim. It becomes warranted only when the mythology predictably damages carriers while securing its own transmission, and when rival explanations such as deliberate sacrifice for a coherent universal principle fit the evidence less well.

A **dark artist**, in the strict use proposed here, is not merely a person who expresses an erroneous or harmful opinion. The term applies to an actor who knowingly and strategically uses deceptive, agency-corroding, or correction-disabling techniques to capture recipients and obtain power, status, money, protection, or destructive effect.

That definition requires evidence of conduct, method, knowledge, incentive, and causal contribution. It must not become a floating label applied to ideological opponents.

33. Apologetic, polemical, and defensive mythology construction

Defence requires more than correcting isolated claims. A destructive actor can change the claim while retaining the same psychological and rhetorical mechanism.

Covert trusted-opinion-leader capture and trusted-channel rebraiding The originating defensive threat model can be stated plainly:

An attacker can try to capture, cultivate, or select a rival field's trusted opinion leaders and other internal guardians, then use their retained internal authority to unbraid the incumbent mythology and rebraid one attacker-favoured successor.

The present framework calls the human-carrier form of this application-level pattern **trusted-opinion-leader capture followed by trusted-channel rebraiding**. It is a proposed Culture Mechanics synthesis, not an established term and not a claim that religious, political, medical, or institutional change normally has this cause. An analogous attack can target an office, institution, appointment system, or communication channel; these are authority structures and authenticated channels, not trusted opinion leaders. The sharpest form is **sentinel inversion**: a person, office, or institution recognized as a guardian of the field becomes the authenticated delivery channel for material that weakens or replaces its load-bearing classifications.

Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity, "Trusted opinion leaders, cascades, and cultivated authority," explains why the target is not merely the person with the largest audience. A high-value trusted opinion leader may combine expertise, personal trust, pastoral care, gatekeeping, translation, brokerage, institutional representation, appointment power, and access to common attention. The attack targets that composite trust and interpretation architecture.

One hypothetical religious scenario makes the causal sequence inspectable without asserting that any real doctrinal change instantiates it:

```
map trusted opinion leaders and the interpretive, pastoral, educational,
publishing, and appointive structures that sustain their authority
      ↓
gain durable influence over selected persons, offices, or succession processes
through concealed dependency, aligned incentives, relational capture,
coercive leverage, selective cultivation, or preferential appointment
      ↓
preserve the carrier's classification as an internal guardian
      ↓
translate rival classifications into authorized incumbent language
      ↓
retain sacred words and symbols while changing their load-bearing bindings
      ↓
use sermons, teaching, conferences, publications, and common reception
to turn vertical authority into visible horizontal acceptance
      ↓
cascade through seminaries, offices, regional leaders, local clergy,
small-group leaders, and ordinary peers
      ↓
embed the successor interpretation in curricula, appointments, funding,
ritual, discipline, publishing, and institutional memory
      ↓
reclassify the incumbent interpretation as alien, harmful, or disloyal
and the successor as faithful, compassionate, mature, or orthodox
      ↓
later participants inherit the rebraided order as normal and internally generated
```

No single acquisition mechanism is essential. Explicit bribery or criminal coercion would be the clearest corruption, but sincere adoption can be more credible and durable. External elite networks can become a leader's main reference group; funding and prestige can alter dependency without purchasing a sentence; institutions can select already aligned candidates; and repeated sponsorship or platform access can cultivate people whose authority later appears organic. The attack can therefore be partly deliberate at the source and sincerely enacted at downstream levels. Distributed implementation does not erase upstream strategy, and upstream strategy does not prove that every carrier knowingly participates.

The pattern can work for six linked reasons:

1. **Authenticated ingress.** An external attack is readily classified as hostile and can strengthen incumbent solidarity. The same proposal carried by a trusted pastor, theologian, editor, expert, or institution arrives as internal interpretation and initially inherits its authorization.
2. **Composite authority and spillover.** Expertise, office, care, character, and group representation can reinforce

one another. Legitimate pastoral or coordination authority may spill into unearned epistemic authority over the disputed claim.

3. **Compatibility as a bridge.** Terms such as *truth, justice, love, compassion, unity, mission, or protection* need not be abandoned. Their mappings to causes, duties, authorities, and permitted conduct can be altered incrementally, making an incompatible destination look like a faithful application during the unbraiding interval.
4. **Common reception and field back-action.** Public address lets participants observe—or imagine—that respected peers received the same interpretation. Silence, repetition, visible adoption, and sanctions can then convert vertical endorsement into apparent horizontal consensus, which acts back upon local judgment.
5. **Nested translation and obscured provenance.** Each internal handoff adapts the message to a smaller jurisdiction. Several apparently independent authorities may derive from one source, while the originating objective, funding, evidence selection, or wording becomes less visible at each stage.
6. **Institutional memory and succession.** Appointments, education, publishing, ritual, and disciplinary rules outlast the initiating people. Once these select and train the next generation of interpreters, the successor can reproduce without continuing direct control from the original attacker.

Under the single-slot principle, this is not the installation of a rival bigOther beside an intact incumbent. If the incoming programme is compatible, it may be integrated or may repair the incumbent without replacement. If it contradicts load-bearing classifications, success requires sufficient loosening and unbraiding for one successor weave to be rebraided. Retained names, offices, scriptures, symbols, memories, and practices receive their operative meaning from that successor. Transitional inconsistency indicates an unstable or tangled lens, not parallel governing evaluators.

The mechanism is truth-neutral, but covertness is not. An internally transmitted correction may be true and emancipatory; a rival successor may be more reality-coupled than the incumbent. The pattern becomes a pathological covert attack when material provenance, dependency, coordination, or sponsor control is deliberately hidden; when coercion or deception substitutes for judgment; or when the successor monopolizes interpretation and disables correction. Rivalry and replacement alone do not establish wrongdoing.

Evidence of doctrinal or policy change is therefore weak evidence of attack, and a payment, grant, friendship, shared vocabulary, or elite association is not proof of capture. A strong inference would require converging evidence such as documented external objectives, concealed material relationships, private coordination, control over evidence or wording, patterned cultivation and appointment, common source dependence behind apparently separate voices, coordinated timing, suppression of provenance, retaliation against correction, and durable institutional effects. The comparison set must include sincere conversion, theological or intellectual development, common response to new evidence, generational replacement, class and career incentives, missionary adaptation, ordinary factional conflict, and independent convergence.

Defence follows from the same mechanism: profile authority by function and jurisdiction; disclose material relationships and participation in message construction; trace sources and transformations; test whether plural voices are causally independent; separate pastoral, coordinative, normative, and epistemic authority; keep appointment and succession processes inspectable; protect internal dissent and external evidence routes; and make corrections travel through the same cascade as the original claim. See “Safeguards for persons, institutions, and cultures” in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*, “Memory, provenance, and correction” in *Epistemic Constitution of Lifted Mechanical Solidarity*, and “LT-037 — Context and source manipulation” in *Linguistic Tricks: A Semantic Inventory*.

For further case investigation, [Megan Basham’s *Shepherds for Sale: How Evangelical Leaders Traded the Truth for a Leftist Agenda*](#) and [Taylor R. Marshall’s *Infiltration: The Plot to Destroy the Church from Within*](#) offer polemical book-length infiltration narratives. They are candidate case claims, not evidence for this threat model. [J. D. Greear’s “An Open Response to Megan Basham’s *Shepherds for Sale*”](#) illustrates why accused participants’ counteraccounts and primary records must be tested before ordinary disagreement is redescribed as covert capture.

Mythological apologetics and polemics Mythological apologetics maintains a constructive mythology under pressure. Mythological polemics contests the braid through which a destructive or failed rival retains authority. Neither operation is reducible to fact-checking because the contested object includes causal stories, moral classifications, identities, status relations, institutions, and permissions.

Constructive apologetics should:

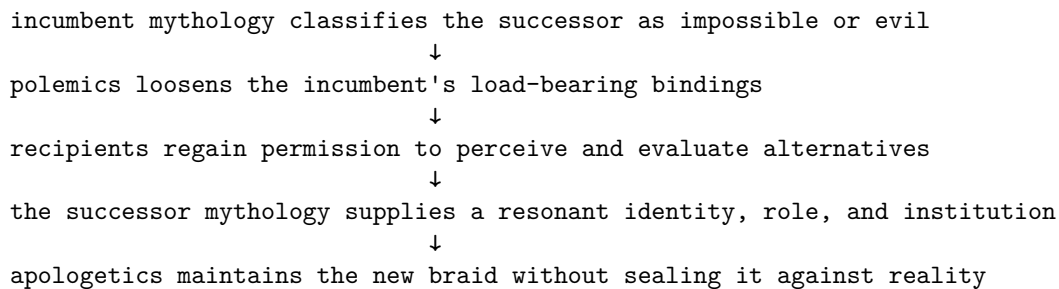
- state the mythology’s load-bearing claims plainly;
- show how symbols connect to real practices and goods;

- answer strong objections rather than ceremonial weak ones;
- admit and repair a false strand without treating the whole identity as lost;
- preserve records of failure and correction;
- demonstrate the mythology through functioning institutions and exemplary conduct.

Constructive polemics should:

- map the rival braid before attacking it;
- identify which strands are factual, causal, moral, identitarian, or institutional;
- distinguish an honoured value from the mechanism claiming to realize it;
- compare the mythology's semantic promise with its operational permission;
- expose contradictions, cost shifting, self-sealing explanations, and impossible counterfactual standards;
- withdraw undeserved authority without indiscriminately humiliating recipients;
- preserve sound strands that can be reattached to the successor mythology;
- present a credible replacement before corrosion becomes generalized cynicism.

The replacement sequence can therefore require attack before adoption:



Polemics is not a licence to lie, dehumanize, or manufacture guilt. Its legitimate object is a demonstrable claim, binding, authority relation, practice, or consequence. Apologetics is not a licence to immunize authority from correction. The two operations become constructive only when they remain answerable to evidence and to the human and institutional consequences of replacement.

33.1 Immunization before capture **Psychological inoculation** originates in [William McGuire's research on resistance to persuasion](#): limited exposure to weakened counterarguments, together with refutation, can stimulate resistance to later persuasion. **Technique-based inoculation** is a more recent extension that teaches people to recognize recurring manipulation before encountering its full-strength form.

[Jon Roozenbeek, Sander van der Linden, Beth Goldberg, Steve Rathje, and Stephan Lewandowsky](#) tested brief inoculation videos addressing emotional manipulation, incoherence, false dichotomies, scapegoating, and ad hominem attacks. Across preregistered experiments and a YouTube field study, the interventions improved manipulation-technique recognition and information discernment.

The proposed mythology-level extension is to teach the downhill signature:

- instant moral elevation;
- impossible or renewable demand;
- compressed enemy;
- cathartic repetition;
- moral permission without reciprocal responsibility;
- explanation of every failure through the mythology itself;
- substitution of symbolic action for capability.

The recipient should learn to ask not only “Is this fact false?” but:

“What reward is this story offering me, what repetition does it recruit, and what will I be less able to do after living inside it?”

33.2 Construct a superior attractor Debunking removes an explanation but may leave untouched the needs it satisfied. A constructive counter-mythology must offer belonging, dignity, agency, significance, protection, and status while attaching them to generative roles.

same available energy

- └ downhill route: accuse, display, demand, repeat
- └ uphill route: learn, build, protect, maintain, repair

The superior attractor should provide:

- attainable first challenges;
- visible growth in competence;
- a community that honours contribution;
- meaningful rationale;
- genuine choice and responsibility;
- exemplars who perform the difficult work;
- rituals marking mastery, service, repair, and truthful correction;
- a future larger than the immediate conflict.

The decisive principle is:

Do not ask people merely to renounce the downhill reward. Offer a resonant and socially supported path by which the same drive can become competence, contribution, and justified pride.

33.3 Recovery and dignified exit Leaving a captured mythology can require surrendering friends, status, certainty, identity, and the belief that previous sacrifices were justified. Humiliation raises the exit cost.

Recovery therefore needs:

- relationships outside the captured network;
- permission to admit doubt incrementally;
- restitution and repair roles;
- recognition for truthful reversal;
- practical routes into work, skill, and community;
- distinction between architects, knowing distributors, imitators, and ordinary recipients;
- protection from endless inherited guilt.

The addiction analogy is useful for understanding reinforcement and relapse, but it must not erase agency or imply that every recipient is permanently lost. Recovery may be difficult, partial, or rare; constructive theory must nevertheless preserve the route.

33.4 Containment and deterrence Testimony without enforcement may warn one audience while the perpetrator moves to another. Deterrence requires real, predictable costs:

detection

↓

evidence and attribution

↓

fair adjudication

↓

proportionate sanction and restitution

↓

public precedent

Depending upon demonstrated conduct and jurisdiction, costs may include:

- correction and right of reply;
- loss of a position of trust;
- professional discipline;
- contractual funding consequences;
- restitution and disgorgement of gains;
- civil or criminal liability for actionable fraud, coercion, threats, or violence;
- exclusion from roles whose duties were knowingly violated.

The intended deterrent expectation is:

“If I knowingly exploit these techniques, the evidence will follow me and the probable costs will exceed the gain.”

It is not fear of indiscriminate harassment, collective punishment, or violence.

34. Destructive culture, causal attribution, and accountability

A **destructive culture**, in the literal functional sense, is a shared order whose classifications and permissions repeatedly convert human energy into the destruction of persons, property, trust, capability, institutions, or inherited social capital.

Visible outputs may include ritualized violence, vandalism, predation, institutional decay, chronic dishonesty, abandonment of maintenance, or celebration of conduct that makes the participants' own environment less habitable.

These outcomes are diagnostic alarms. They are not completed causal attribution.

VISIBLE DESTRUCTION

↓
identify the legitimating mythology
↓
reconstruct its Perception-Context-Permission sequence
↓
trace transmission, incentives, and institutional reinforcement
↓
identify knowing actors and demonstrable conduct
↓
test rival causal explanations
↓
adjudicate responsibility and impose proportionate costs

Different destructive events may arise from different mechanisms even when their surface form resembles one another. Riot, criminal predation, political violence, celebratory disorder, crowd contagion, and institutionalized corruption should not be collapsed into one causal story without evidence.

The originating example points specifically to regularly burning cars in suburbs of Paris and to street violence after football matches. These are visible products of destructive culture in the literal sense: human energy, shared permission, and collective excitement are being converted into damaged persons, property, trust, and habitat. Their concreteness matters. A theory that cannot name such outputs risks turning destruction into an abstraction.

The outputs are nevertheless not self-explanatory. A burned car after a football match and a burned car during unrest in a Parisian suburb present a similar visible loss, but the first may arise from celebratory transgression, crowd contagion, status display, or opportunism; the second may be organized through grievance, territorial identity, resistance, predation, or some combination. The material symptom can be seen "by eye," while the mythology, incentives, knowing contributors, and appropriate remedy must still be reconstructed separately. Similar smoke does not prove an identical fire.

The working maxim is:

Social destruction is the smoke alarm. Mythological analysis locates the fire. Causal attribution identifies who knowingly supplied the fuel.

Anger at betrayal can become useful energy when it is sublimated into investigation, documentation, collective claims, restitution, protection, and persistent enforcement. Anger is fuel; due process supplies steering and brakes. Without institutional form, retaliatory anger can reproduce the same enemy fixation, catharsis, and downhill repetition it opposes.

The accountability boundary is therefore strict:

Sanctions attach to demonstrable conduct and causal responsibility, not merely to possession or expression of a disliked mythology.

From theory to the Mythology Construction Toolkit

35. Construction workflow

The authority boundary precedes the workflow: *Systems Leadership* remains the definitive source for implementing a culture as a whole, including the necessary coordination of mythology with systems, symbols, habits, leadership behaviour, and repeated experience. This workflow addresses the mythology layer and must not be treated as a replacement for the book's complete method.

Within that boundary, the **Mythology Construction Toolkit** turns the mythology-specific theory into an iterative design process. Its large workflow is intentional: population-and-ecology diagnosis, resonance, braid replacement, epistemic safeguards, reality coupling, and adversarial defence require extended treatment beyond the book's workplace focus. It is not a recipe for maximizing compliance. Every stage includes a reality, agency, and consequence check.

Stage 1: Define the real coordination problem State the condition that requires cultural cooperation.

- What cannot be solved by isolated individual action?
- Across which population must coordination occur?
- Which material, institutional, developmental, or epistemic outcome matters?
- Who bears the costs of action, error, and inaction?
- What would count as improvement?

The initial problem statement should remain revisable. Otherwise the mythology can become an elaborate solution to a strategically misclassified condition.

Stage 2: Declare normative and constitutional boundaries Before optimizing resonance, specify constraints:

- factual claims remain corrigible;
- persons retain dignity and meaningful exit;
- responsibility remains evidence-sensitive;
- permissions remain compatible with law and due process;
- a lifted answer generator may govern universally while keeping its persons, offices, institutions, and first-order outputs within allocated jurisdictions;
- reframing may not conceal contradictory promises;
- no authority receives final control over reality;
- constructive ends do not license arbitrary means.

These boundaries are part of the design, not decorations added after success.

Stage 3: Diagnose the society and its existing mythology Map:

- moral intuitions and motives;
- expressed dispositions;
- causal worldviews;
- identities and historical memories;
- trusted and distrusted authorities;
- institutions, rituals, rewards, and sanctions;
- network bridges and isolated clusters;
- current downhill attractors;
- existing sublimations and capabilities;
- material feedback channels.

Then map the incumbent mythology as a braid:

- Which stories, identities, symbols, rituals, and institutions cross-bind one another?
- Which strands are load-bearing, and which are ornamental?
- Which apologetic responses repair the braid under challenge?
- Which polemical classifications pre-emptively discredit alternatives?
- Which strands preserve real knowledge or social goods and should survive any replacement?

Map its apologetic and polemical actor structure:

- Which persons, offices, and institutions currently occupy the relevant slots?
- Which actors possess merely a voice, and which possess recognized authority?
- By what combination of disposition, lineage, credential, appointment, reputation, ritual, or procedure were they selected?
- Which recognition community ratifies or rejects them?
- Does authority belong to the person, the office, the institution, or an unstable mixture?
- What happens at succession, schism, institutional failure, or loss of credibility?

The principal outputs are a **population-and-ecology map**, an **incumbent-braid map**, and an **actor-slot map**, not a single demographic persona.

Stage 4: Specify the constructive destination Describe what the mythology should make more possible over time:

- which capabilities should grow;
- which relationships should become more trustworthy;
- which institutions should become more adaptive;
- which practices should be maintained;
- which drives require sublimation;
- which coordination should widen;
- what successors should inherit.

This is the **life-drive and reality-coupling specification**.

Stage 5: Map resonance and construct a mythology family For each relevant subgroup, ask:

- What moral language makes the destination intelligible?
- Which identity can own the role without self-betrayal?
- Which costs will be experienced as honourable rather than imposed humiliation?
- Which trusted exemplars can embody it?
- Which shared second-order symbols can join the variants?

The output is a family of morally intelligible but operationally compatible variants.

Stage 6: Build the construction grammar Specify:

- world model and historical memory;
- desired and feared futures;
- topoi and plot;
- causal stories;
- protagonists, beneficiaries, obstacles, and responsible actors;
- sacred values and master signifiers;
- identity and role offers;
- Perception-Context-Permission sequence;
- concrete practices and expected consequences;
- rival causal stories and distinguishing evidence.

Cross-bind each important claim to more than one embodied support where possible: remembered example, moral intuition, role, ritual, institution, and observable consequence. Redundancy should preserve meaning under ordinary strain without protecting falsehood from correction.

The outputs are a **mythology grammar** and a **successor-braid map**, not merely a slogan list.

Stage 7: Design the psychological gradient Inventory the raw motives and rewards already available. Then ask how each can be routed.

Available energy	Downhill capture risk	Constructive route
Anger	Scapegoating and catharsis	Investigation, protection, disciplined enforcement
Status desire	Performative moral superiority	Mastery, service, earned honour
Care	Dependency and boundaryless rescue	Competent help, restoration, reciprocal capacity

Available energy	Downhill capture risk	Constructive route
Anti-dominance	Enemy fixation and indiscriminate destruction	Due process, distributed power, protection from actual coercion
Loyalty	Suppression of truth for the group	Faithful correction and long-term stewardship
Autonomy	Rejection of every limit	Self-command, responsibility, and protected personal domain
Desire for order	Rigid authority and closure	Reliable procedure, planning, and maintainable institutions
Desire for meaning	Impossible final demand	Vocation, generativity, and work extending beyond the self

Create small attainable challenges, visible feedback, apprenticeship, and recognition for contribution. The aim is to make entry possible without disguising the upward gradient.

Stage 8: Embody the mythology Translate the grammar into:

- exemplars;
- rituals and calendars;
- education and apprenticeship;
- institutional roles;
- selection and promotion;
- recognition and sanction;
- material infrastructure;
- records and memory;
- ordinary etiquette and repeated practice.

Allocate apologetic and polemical agency explicitly:

- Which functions require a trusted person, and which require a persistent institution?
- How are candidates drawn toward, trained for, and admitted to each slot?
- What kind of recognition makes their speech authoritative?
- How does the office survive succession without becoming detached from its purpose?
- Who may challenge, correct, remove, or replace a failed actor?

Every symbolic claim should have an operational counterpart. If the mythology honours stewardship, someone must maintain something real. If it honours truth, correction must receive visible protection.

Stage 9: Activate, transmit, and prototype Use limited and reversible trials where possible. Observe how recipients retell the mythology, which parts they omit, which antagonists they invent, and which actions they infer.

Participatory testing asks recipients to explain:

- what happened in the story;
- what caused it;
- who “we” are;
- what someone like them should do;
- what evidence could change the interpretation;
- what costs and rewards they expect.

The mythology actually received is more important than the mythology the constructor intended.

Stage 10: Measure, correct, defend, and retire Track psychological, behavioural, institutional, material, and intergenerational effects. Preserve dissent, failed predictions, reinterpretations, and adverse outcomes.

Run adversarial tests:

- hostile reframing;
- symbol displacement;
- polemical strand isolation and attempted unbraiding;
- corrosion of confidence through comparison with an undefined ideal;

- delegitimation without a declared replacement;
- capture of an apologetic or polemical slot by a self-appointed claimant;
- conversion of institutional authority into personal charismatic rule;
- use of institutional voice to defend organizational survival against institutional purpose;
- accusation in a mirror;
- persuasive redefinition;
- qualified-concept inversion: compare semantic wrapper with operational payload;
- enemy compression;
- self-sealing failure explanations;
- capture by opportunistic institutions;
- drift from role performance into identity display;
- Babelizing effects across subgroups.

Test its actors as rigorously as their arguments: why does this person or institution occupy the slot, who recognizes that authority, which dispositions and incentives does the selection process favour, and can the actor be corrected or replaced? Test its apologetics as rigorously as the attack: can defenders answer the strongest objection, admit error, and repair a strand without treating disagreement as betrayal? If replacement is intended, specify the unbraiding sequence, the strands to preserve, the bridge across the liminal interval, and the institutions that can carry the successor before the incumbent loses all authority.

A mythology must be revised when its means no longer produce its stated ends. It must be retired when correction cannot restore reality coupling without preserving a destructive attractor. Retirement should be treated as guided unbraiding and rebraiding, not abandonment into a semantic vacuum.

36. Evaluation criteria

Engagement, recall, and agreement are insufficient measures. Evaluation should span the complete causal chain.

Evaluation level	Example questions
Reception	Was the mythology understood, remembered, and experienced as recognition rather than alien imposition?
Internalization	Can participants state reasons, modify the account, and act without constant surveillance?
Psychological gradient	Which immediate rewards and avoidance patterns sustain participation?
Drive direction	Do repeated actions build capability, relationship, creation, maintenance, and posterity?
Role enactment	Are participants doing the reality-facing work or mainly displaying identity?
Institutional embodiment	Do rules, rewards, appointments, rituals, and budgets tell the same story?
Coordination	Can differentiated actors contribute without forced uniformity?
Coupling range	Does cooperation cross the groups required for the task?
Epistemic integrity	Can evidence, dissent, and failure revise the mythology?
Material consequence	What happens to health, safety, production, trust, ecology, infrastructure, and prosperity?
Exit and recovery	Can a participant leave, change mind, repair harm, and retain ordinary dignity?
Braid integrity	Do its mutually supporting strands create durability without concealing contradiction or error?
Apologetic corrigibility	Can it defend its goods, answer strong objections, and repair false strands?
Polemical precision	Can it contest a failed rival without dissolving sound knowledge, ordinary trust, or the possibility of replacement?
Actor–slot fit	Do the dispositions, competence, credibility, and incentives of the selected actors fit the function they perform?

Evaluation level	Example questions
Authorization integrity	Is authority genuinely recognized through the relevant solidarity order, or merely asserted, captured, or simulated?
Institutional continuity	Can the function survive succession while remaining corrigible and faithful to its purpose?
Adversarial resilience	Can the mythology resist dark arts without adopting them?
Intergenerational consequence	What dispositions, institutions, debts, skills, and environments are handed forward?

Several metrics require long horizons. A mythology can generate immediate unity by consuming trust, savings, infrastructure, fertility, reputation, or institutional independence accumulated by previous generations. Short-term mobilization should therefore be evaluated alongside changes in inherited capital.

A practical scorecard should preserve separate measures rather than collapse them into one number. High resonance cannot compensate automatically for destructive consequence; high material output cannot compensate automatically for systemic lying or coercive capture.

37. Testable hypotheses and research programme

The framework is intended to generate falsifiable research rather than explain every outcome after the fact.

Hypothesis	Prediction	Possible test
Universal activation	Some mythological structures activate species-typical mechanisms across populations.	Cross-cultural experiments using common narrative and moral stimuli.
Dispositional modulation	Different dispositional configurations respond differently to the same mythology.	Pre-measured traits interacted with randomized narrative exposure.
Resonance interaction	Matched mythology produces greater transportation, retention, identification, and enactment than unmatched mythology.	Preregistered factorial experiments comparing matched and mismatched frames and roles.
Age amplification	Receptivity differences associated with dispositions increase as people select congruent niches.	Longitudinal studies of traits, environments, mythology exposure, and response.
Polygenic prediction	Future polygenic scores predict some differential mythology receptivity.	Prospective genomic studies with out-of-sample prediction and strict population controls.
Incremental prediction	Polygenic scores add prediction beyond demographics and self-report.	Nested models evaluated on held-out samples.
Cultural-niche reinforcement	Adoption leads people to select relationships and institutions that reinforce the mythology.	Longitudinal network and migration studies after conversion or identity change.
Cultural-meta-environment	Distributed mythological and institutional environments create systematic non-genetic formation not captured by the shared household.	Designs separating household, peer-network, institutional, media, regional, and cohort exposure while modelling genetic similarity.
Gene-culture feedback	Durable mythologies alter status, partner choice, fertility, migration, or survival in ways that change selection pressures.	Historical-demographic and genomic analysis with rival causal models.

Hypothesis	Prediction	Possible test
Fast evolution	Persistent cultural selection pressures produce detectable dispositional change over historical time.	Ancient and modern genomic comparisons linked to documented changes in marriage, status, fertility, migration, or survival.
Population-history	Historical gene-culture trajectories predict different response distributions across societies.	Multi-population replications with measurement-invariance and ancestry-sensitive designs.
Producer-guardian	Producer-like and guardian-like configurations form partially stable, possibly heritable clusters with different mythology preferences.	Latent-profile, twin, genomic, and experimental-receptivity studies.
Marriage-mediated coupling range	Weaker intensive kinship predicts wider non-kin trust and greater resonance of impersonal civic mythology.	Kinship-network, institutional, historical, and cross-cultural studies.
Lifted-solidarity compatibility	Democracy is more durable where political loss remains compatible with shared membership and impersonal law.	Comparative institutional studies measuring civic meta-solidarity rather than formal rules alone.
Genetic-hardware fit	Dispositional or polygenic differences predict the cost and durability of sustaining impersonal office, loyal opposition, and abstract civic reciprocity.	Matched institutional comparisons combined with longitudinal dispositional and genomic measures.
Babelization	Rising local mythological coherence combined with declining intergroup semantic overlap predicts failure of society-wide coordination.	Longitudinal language, network, trust, and collective-action measures.
Culture-mixing threshold	Collective agency declines when incompatible first-order mythologies multiply faster than credible second-order integration.	Longitudinal comparison of migration or subcultural fragmentation rates, semantic overlap, civic identity, and coordination outcomes.
Directed guardian empathy	Care persists more strongly for a hostile actor classified as oppressed than for an equivalent hostile actor classified as dominant.	Factorial experiments independently varying harm, hostility, group power, and ideological identity.
Carrier-replicator divergence	Some mythologies increase their own transmission through costly carrier behaviour even while reducing carrier capability or survival.	Longitudinal studies measuring transmission against health, capability, reciprocity, fertility, and exit costs.
Downhill capture	Immediate moral and social rewards predict retention even when promised outcomes repeatedly fail.	Experiments and longitudinal studies separating outcome satisfaction from ritualized repetition.
Constructive attractor	Belonging and status attached to real mastery outperform debunking alone in durable exit from destructive mythology.	Randomized or quasi-experimental recovery and prevention programmes.
Reality coupling	Mythologies attached to observable adaptive practices correct more effectively than symbolically insulated mythologies.	Comparative field studies of institutions with different feedback structures.

Hypothesis	Prediction	Possible test
Braided redundancy	Mythologies whose central meanings are supported by compatible story, role, ritual, and institution survive loss of any single expression better than slogan-centred campaigns.	Network analysis and controlled removal of communication or institutional supports.
Polemical vacancy	Negative delegitimation without an embodied successor increases generalized cynicism, anomie, or capture by a third mythology.	Longitudinal studies of institutional trust and identity following successful negative campaigns.
Controlled replacement	Preserving sound strands and transition roles during unbraiding produces more stable adoption than total repudiation of the incumbent.	Comparative historical studies and field experiments on organizational or civic reform.
Systemic-slot selection	People who become recognized apologetic or polemical actors display relevant dispositional and network characteristics before formal appointment or public recognition.	Prospective studies of candidates, trajectories into roles, personality, status networks, and later recognition.
Recognition premium	The same argument has greater cultural effect when voiced by an actor ratified by the relevant solidarity order than by a self-appointed claimant.	Experiments varying identical messages by speaker, office, institutional endorsement, and audience identity.
Authority scaling	First-order solidarity concentrates apologetic and polemical authority more strongly in embodied persons, whereas lifted solidarity locates more of it in persistent offices and institutions.	Comparative studies measuring person-dependence, office continuity, succession, and response to actor replacement.
Institutional-actor persistence	Where the institution is the effective actor, recognizable apologetic or polemical policy persists across turnover of individual representatives.	Interrupted time-series and succession studies of courts, churches, parties, professions, universities, and media organizations.
Pathological selection	Death-driven or self-protective systems preferentially select actors whose dispositions support rationalization, persecution, closure, or institutional survival over stated purpose.	Longitudinal selection studies comparing recruitment, promotion, dissent tolerance, and consequence-bearing across institutions.

Polygenic research requires special methodological discipline. Scores developed in one ancestry or institutional environment may not transport cleanly to another; population stratification, assortative mating, indirect genetic effects, and gene–environment correlation complicate interpretation. These are not reasons to exclude genetics from the theory. They determine the design standards required for a credible test.

The strongest evidence would be prospective and incremental:

```

pre-registered dispositional or polygenic prediction
      ↓
random assignment to matched and mismatched mythology
      ↓
measured transportation, identification, retention, and behaviour
      ↓
out-of-sample replication
      ↓
predicted mediation through the relevant moral or motivational mechanism

```

38. Illustrative applications and hypotheses

The following applications show how the general framework can organize inquiry. They are not all established conclusions.

Balinese subak The water-temple system illustrates reality-coupled mythology: sacred order, democratic association, ecological coordination, and observable feedback reinforce one another.

Producer and egalitarian guardian The pair illustrates differential moral resonance, complementary roles, status conflict, and the possibility that a protective cultural immune system becomes autoimmune when it misclassifies sustaining structures as enemies.

Enlightenment and Counter-Enlightenment One proposed interpretation treats property, contract, markets, impersonal law, and individual rights as an **individual-sovereignty technology suite** transmitted partly through Enlightenment mythology. That suite is a term proposed in this synthesis. Counter-Enlightenment mythology may redescribe those institutions as concealed domination and ordinary acceptance as **false consciousness**. The latter expression is borrowed from [Friedrich Engels's 1893 letter to Franz Mehring](#), but its use here is deliberately not identical: Engels used it within historical materialism for an ideologue's unrecognized real motives, whereas this application treats it as a mythological device for invalidating ordinary acceptance of an institutional order.

This application generates historical and genetic hypotheses:

- that European populations underwent changes in individualist dispositions through gene–culture coevolution;
- that Enlightenment mythology resonated especially with those dispositions;
- that collectivist counter-mythologies resonated with a differently weighted part of the population;
- that institutional and reproductive consequences subsequently reinforced or altered those distributions.

These claims require historical, behavioural-genetic, genomic, and cross-cultural testing. Their place in the theory is generative: they specify what evidence would strengthen or weaken the account.

Freud and Bernays: unbraiding and rebraiding [Sigmund Freud's introductory lectures on psychoanalysis](#) present a structured inquiry into unconscious connections, dreams, symptoms, resistance, and repetition. At the level of the present analogy, psychoanalysis is an art of **untying**: it follows apparently disconnected strands, reconstructs how they became bound, and makes an inherited or symptomatic formation available for reinterpretation.

Freud's nephew [Edward Bernays](#) became a pioneer of public relations and described organized opinion formation in [Propaganda](#). At the level of the analogy, propaganda is an art of **weaving**: it joins desire, prestige, authority, symbol, event, and public conduct so that a new association becomes culturally available and eventually ordinary.

This produces a memorable family symmetry:

Freud: structured inquiry into an existing psychic formation

↓

untying the braid

Bernays: structured organization of symbols and public associations

↓

weaving a new braid

The symmetry is interpretive rather than a complete intellectual history. Freud did not define psychoanalysis as population-level mythological deprogramming, and Bernays's practice cannot be reduced to psychoanalytic theory. Their relationship makes tangible, however, that the ability to dissolve an installed configuration and the ability to install a successor are complementary technologies.

Critical Theory and cynical corrosion [Max Horkheimer's "Traditional and Critical Theory"](#) is an early canonical statement of Frankfurt School Critical Theory. Horkheimer's stated project was not contentless negation: he connected critique to empirical disciplines and to the positive aim of giving social life a rational form.

The mythology-construction framework nevertheless treats a particular **critical-theoretical operation** as an important polemical failure mode:

real institution under unavoidable constraints
 ↓
 comparison with an unspecified or impossible ideal
 ↓
 every compromise reclassified as guilt or concealed domination
 ↓
 ordinary confidence becomes evidence of naïveté or false consciousness
 ↓
 incumbent mythology loses authority before a viable successor is exposed to test

In its strongest formulation, this is a tool for delegitimizing a real thing for not being an ideal thing that cannot exist. It works as corrosive acid on an inherited worldview: it need not know the positive destination in operational detail, because its immediate task is to dissolve the recipient's faith in the present braid. Dialectical or revolutionary replacement can then occur after the incumbent's symbolic defences have failed.

The originating verdict is intentionally moral, not merely descriptive: this is a wicked tool, used almost always to undermine something legitimate so that something illegitimate can replace it through dialectical movement.

That sentence contains two claims of different kinds. **Wicked** is the framework's normative judgment about knowingly using indiscriminate corrosion to destroy justified confidence. **Almost always** is a strong empirical generalization and therefore a research hypothesis: it would require comparative historical and textual evidence about targets, feasible alternatives, disclosed successor arrangements, and actual consequences. Its evidential burden frames the judgment; it is not a reason to delete it.

This is the present framework's verdict about the operation it identifies, not [Max Horkheimer's](#) definition of his own programme. Critique can expose real domination, contradiction, deception, and avoidable suffering. The corrosive operation must therefore be demonstrated through its standards of comparison, treatment of constraints, concealment of alternatives, and replacement effects rather than inferred merely from the label *Critical Theory*.

[Helen Pluckrose and James A. Lindsay's *Cynical Theories*](#) is relevant prior art because the authors trace what they regard as a development from postmodern theory into activist orthodoxies that threaten science, reason, liberal ethics, and open debate. The **acid** image is not presented as their phrase. Here it names the more general mythology-construction mechanism by which habitual suspicion can dissolve one governing worldview without yet earning confidence in another.

Constrained and unconstrained visions [Thomas Sowell's *A Conflict of Visions*](#) distinguishes visions that emphasize permanent human limitation and trade-offs from visions that place greater confidence in reasoned social improvement. Mythology construction treats such visions as causal-worldview priors. The same proposal may be rejected before its values are considered because it presupposes an incompatible account of human nature, knowledge, power, and unintended consequence.

Democracy export This application distinguishes exporting visible institutions from constructing the lifted solidarity, impersonal trust, and mythology of legitimate opposition that allow those institutions to reproduce themselves.

Marriage rules and social radius This application tests whether rules governing close-kin marriage can jointly change reproductive structure, alliance networks, trust radius, institutional form, and the mythologies capable of travelling through the population.

Babelization This application treats semantic fragmentation as a destruction of collective agency: local groups retain strong mythology while the society loses a common symbolic protocol for formulating and pursuing goals.

Destructive culture This application begins with observable damage, reconstructs the mythology and PCP sequence that made it intelligible, and then tests causal attribution before assigning responsibility.

39. Diagnostic questions

Definition and purpose

- What exactly is the mythology intended to construct?

- Which real coordination problem does it address?
- Which outcomes would distinguish success from mere replication?
- Whose flourishing and whose costs are included?

Resonance

- Which species-typical mechanisms does the mythology activate?
- Which dispositional configuration does it fit?
- Which moral taste buds and motives receive emphasis?
- Which causal worldview does it assume?
- Does it offer recognition or require identity humiliation?
- Are several compatible variants required?

Grammar and PCP

- What are the topoi and causal plot?
- Who receives agency, intention, responsibility, and victimhood?
- Which sacred objects and master signifiers organize the field?
- What identity and concrete role are offered?
- What does the mythology make perceptible?
- Which context does it supply?
- What does it thereby permit or require?
- Which rival causal story fits the same observations?

Braiding, apologetics, polemics, and replacement

- Which strands form the incumbent rope of logic?
- Which programming packages are compatible constituents of the one incumbent weave, and where do rival packages contradict its load-bearing classifications?
- Does the analysis mistakenly rank parallel governing programs instead of testing compatible composition, rejection, or unbraid/rebraid replacement?
- Which cross-bindings carry its governing authority?
- Which strands are false or destructive, and which preserve recoverable knowledge or social goods?
- Does its apologetics answer strong objections and repair error, or reinterpret every objection as hostility?
- What exactly must polemics unbraid before the successor can become intelligible?
- Does the polemic compare the incumbent with a feasible alternative or an undefined perfection?
- What bridge prevents the liminal interval from becoming generalized cynicism, anomie, or third-party capture?
- Are successor roles, rituals, and institutions ready before the incumbent loses authority?
- Which incumbent strands will survive, and what operative meaning will their new bindings give them in the successor weave?
- Is the successor a first-order or lifted full capture: do participants share its concrete answers or the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise them?
- Who bears the transition costs and responsibility for the permissions created by replacement?

Actors, slots, and authority

- Which apologetic and polemical slots does the solidarity field create?
- Who currently occupies each slot: a person, office, institution, or informal network?
- Is the visible human speaking personally or as the representative of a persistent institutional actor?
- Which dispositions, motives, abilities, and biographical features drew the actor toward the role?
- How did the relevant group or institution recognize, ratify, appoint, or reject the claimant?
- Would the same words carry the same force from someone outside the recognized slot?
- Is authority grounded in lineage, charisma, ritual, credential, procedure, reputation, office, or some combination?
- Was the node recognized organically, appointed internally, externally amplified, deliberately cultivated, or selected through a dependency-shaped succession process?
- Which source, funder, evidence package, communication network, or appointment pathway is shared by apparently independent authorities?
- How did the message change as it passed through expert, institutional, regional, pastoral, and peer channels?

- Can the actor distinguish defence of the mythology's purpose from defence of personal or organizational survival?
- What happens when the actor fails, dies, retires, defects, or loses legitimacy?
- Can succession preserve authority without suppressing correction or recreating personal rule?
- Does the analysis mistake a bounded representative institution for the universal lifted meta-order, or allow an office to spill beyond its allocated jurisdiction?

Psychological gradient

- What immediate reward makes entry attractive?
- Is desire converted into an impossible or renewable demand?
- Does participation produce capability or mainly recognition?
- Is anger transformed into protection and investigation or consumed through catharsis?
- Does the mythology educate taste or preserve immaturity?
- Does each repetition make exit more difficult?

Drive direction and sublimation

- Which raw drives are being released, repressed, or sublimated?
- What becomes easier after one year of participation?
- What skills, relationships, institutions, and inheritances are created?
- What is consumed without replacement?
- Does difficulty serve life, or has sacrifice itself become a death-driven ritual?

Embodiment

- Which practices, rituals, calendars, offices, and rewards tell the same story?
- Do admired exemplars perform the difficult work?
- Does the budget embody the stated sacred values?
- What happens during crisis, failure, and succession?

Social scale

- At what radius must cooperation operate?
- Does the mythology bridge groups or intensify one local cluster?
- Can political or institutional losers remain members?
- Are central terms mutually intelligible across subcultures?
- Is synchronization calibrated to preserve independent judgment?
- Does the proposal strengthen lifted solidarity or Babelization?
- Which installed meta-rules generate the relevant first-order answers, and which of them allocate, limit, coordinate, and correct jurisdictions?

Reality and epistemic constitution

- What evidence could reduce confidence in the mythology?
- Who records failed predictions and adverse consequences?
- Can authorities admit error without loss of their entire identity?
- Are correction routes causally independent?
- Can a recipient leave with dignity?
- Does failure cause revision or demands for greater commitment?

Adversarial defence and accountability

- Which dark-art techniques could capture or invert the mythology?
- Could a trusted guardian become an authenticated delivery channel through capture of a trusted opinion leader or of the institution or channel they represent, including sentinel inversion?
- Are provenance, material relationships, message construction, and source dependence visible at every stage of the cascade?
- Can recipients recognize the downhill honey-trap signature?

- Is there a superior constructive role, not merely a debunking message?
- Are recovery routes available?
- Are sanctions tied to demonstrable conduct, causal responsibility, and due process?
- Could the label “dark artist” itself become an enemy-construction trick?

Terminological provenance and boundaries

This section separates three kinds of language:

1. **retained:** used substantially in its cited source sense;
2. **borrowed and extended:** recognizably derived from a cited author, but given a broader, narrower, or different operational role here;
3. **proposed here:** part of the present synthesis and not attributed to an external author.

A citation under “retained” supports the named concept, not every inference later made from it. A concept under “borrowed and extended” must not be quoted back to its originator as though the adapted definition were theirs.

40. Established concepts retained substantially in their source sense

- **Practical culture implementation through leadership behaviour, systems, symbols, mythologies, habits, organizational arrangements, and repeated experience**—Ian Macdonald, Catherine Burke, and Karl Stewart: *Systems Leadership: Creating Positive Organisations*. Culture Mechanics retains this as its definitive practical method and judges it approximately 99% correct. Translation into **bigOther** architecture and extension beyond the organizational and workplace focus belong to the present framework.
- **Mechanical and organic solidarity** — Émile Durkheim: *De la division du travail social*.
- **Collective representations, ritual, and collective effervescence** — Émile Durkheim: *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life*.
- **Moral Foundations Theory** — Jonathan Haidt, Craig Joseph, Jesse Graham, and collaborators: *Moral Foundations Theory publications*.
- **Biology as a first draft elaborated by cultural learning** — Jonathan Haidt: *The Righteous Mind*.
- **Narrative transportation** — Melanie Green and Timothy Brock: “The Role of Transportation in the Persuasiveness of Public Narratives”.
- **Framing** — Robert Entman: “Framing: Toward Clarification of a Fractured Paradigm”.
- **Causal stories** — Deborah Stone: “Causal Stories and the Formation of Policy Agendas”.
- **Defensive and offensive apologetics** — John G. Stackhouse: “Defining, Directing, and Defending Apologetics”.
- **Apologetics and polemics as distinguishable theological functions** — Friedrich Schleiermacher: *Brief Outline of the Study of Theology*.
- **Psychoanalytic inquiry into unconscious formations, resistance, and symptoms** — Sigmund Freud: *A General Introduction to Psychoanalysis*.
- **Organized public-opinion formation and propaganda** — Edward Bernays: *Propaganda*.
- **Critical Theory** — Max Horkheimer: “Traditional and Critical Theory”.
- **Critique of postmodern and activist theories** — Helen Pluckrose and James A. Lindsay: *Cynical Theories*.
- **Active gene–environment correlation** — Robert Plomin, John DeFries, and John Loehlin: “Genotype–Environment Interaction and Correlation in the Analysis of Human Behavior”.
- **Active niche selection and construction** — Sandra Scarr and Kathleen McCartney: “How People Make Their Own Environments”.
- **Polygenic inheritance and scores in behavioural genetics** — Robert Plomin: *Blueprint*.
- **Increasing heritability of cognitive ability across development** — Daniel Briley and Elliot Tucker-Drob: “Explaining the Increasing Heritability of Cognitive Ability across Development”.
- **Quantitative cultural evolution and gene–culture coevolution** — L. Luca Cavalli-Sforza and Marcus Feldman, later Robert Boyd, Peter Richerson, Joseph Henrich, and other dual-inheritance theorists: *Marcus Feldman’s account of the programme’s origins* and “Gene–Culture Coevolution in the Age of Genomics”.
- **Kinship intensity and psychological variation** — Jonathan Schulz, Duman Bahrami-Rad, Jonathan Beauchamp, and Joseph Henrich: “The Church, Intensive Kinship, and Global Psychological Variation”.
- **Articulation and hegemony** — Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe: *Hegemony and Socialist Strategy*.
- **Folk devil** — Stanley Cohen: *Folk Devils and Moral Panics*.
- **Organizational culture embedding** — Edgar Schein: *Organizational Culture and Leadership*.
- **Self-Determination Theory** — Edward Deci and Richard Ryan: “The ‘What’ and ‘Why’ of Goal Pursuits”.
- **Psychological inoculation** — William McGuire: “Resistance to Persuasion Conferred by Active and Passive Prior Refutation”. **Technique-based misinformation inoculation** — Jon Roozenbeek, Sander van der Linden, Beth

Goldberg, Steve Rathje, and Stephan Lewandowsky: “Psychological Inoculation Improves Resilience against Misinformation on Social Media”.

- **Perspective-getting through nonjudgmental narrative exchange** — Joshua Kalla and David Broockman: “Reducing Exclusionary Attitudes through Interpersonal Conversation”.
- **Balinese water-temple networks as complex adaptive systems** — J. Stephen Lansing and James Kremer: “Emergent Properties of Balinese Water Temple Networks”.
- **Hairworm alteration of cricket water-entry behaviour** — Frédéric Thomas and colleagues: “Do Hairworms Manipulate the Water Seeking Behaviour of Their Terrestrial Hosts?”.
- **Constrained and unconstrained visions** — Thomas Sowell: *A Conflict of Visions*.

41. Borrowed concepts deliberately extended here

The following terms retain a recognizable source lineage but receive a new functional role in this synthesis.

Mythology and mythological lens **Status: borrowed and substantially extended.** The framework adapts terminology from Ian Macdonald, Catherine Burke, and Karl Stewart’s *Systems Leadership: Creating Positive Organisations* and joins it to Durkheimian collective representation, narrative theory, cultural evolution, and the newly proposed culture-mechanics model. A mythology here is not merely a sacred tale; it is a connected system of evaluated narrative meaning that trains population-level classification and can be embodied and reinforced through symbols, practices, systems, and institutions. Those implementation channels are not thereby reduced to mythology. The full extended definition should not be attributed to the Systems Leadership authors.

This extension of terminology and theoretical range is not a general correction of the book’s culture-implementation method. Culture Mechanics treats that practical method as definitive and approximately 99% correct; departures must be named as extensions or revisions rather than attributed back to Macdonald, Burke, and Stewart.

bigOther **Status: borrowed and substantially extended.** The spelling **bigOther** adapts Jacques Lacan’s *big Other* into the culturally installed sentiment-classifier of culture mechanics. This is not Lacan’s own computational or systems model.

Desire, demand, jouissance, death-drive, and life-drive **Status: Lacanian concepts, culturally operationalized here.** The operative meanings of death-drive and life-drive come from Jacques Lacan’s *Seminar XI* and “Position of the Unconscious” in *Écrits*, together with his concepts of desire, demand, jouissance, repetition, and the drive circuit. Freud is the historical precursor to Lacan’s discussion, but the terms are not used here in a merely Freudian biological or dual-instinct sense. Lacan treats life-drive and death-drive as two aspects of drive and describes every drive as virtually a death drive. The present synthesis extends that structure into a cultural diagnostic: **death-drive mythology** names self-reproducing repetition and jouissance that consume their human or institutional carriers, while **life-drive mythology** names symbolic binding and sublimation that accumulate capability, relationship, creation, maintenance, and posterity. Those society-level criteria are the framework’s application, not quotations from Lacan.

Sublimation **Status: borrowed and extended.** The term derives principally from Sigmund Freud’s *psychoanalysis*. The present framework extends it from individual drive transformation into a theory of shared institutional practices, moral formation, and civilizational character.

Topos and mythos **Status: borrowed and extended.** *Topos* and *mythos* come from Aristotle’s *rhetoric* and *poetics*. Here *topos* includes recurring cultural scenes as well as argument locations, while *mythos* includes society-wide causal-historical plots as well as dramatic plot structure.

Master signifier **Status: borrowed and operationally extended.** The term comes from Jacques Lacan’s *Seminar XVII* and enters political discourse theory through Laclau. Here it also names any compact symbol capable of activating a mythology’s wider classification field; that design-oriented use is not identical to Lacan’s S1.

Sacred values and sacred objects **Status: borrowed and extended.** Protected and sacred values are developed by Jonathan Baron and Mark Spranca, Philip Tetlock and colleagues, and Scott Atran, Jeremy Ginges, and collaborators. The present definition broadens the object from trade-off-resistant values to symbols, places, practices, relationships, and institutions treated as morally non-fungible.

Moral taste buds **Status: borrowed metaphor, expanded machinery.** [Jonathan Haidt and collaborators](#) use the taste-receptor analogy for plural, partly evolved moral foundations whose expression is culturally elaborated. The present framework retains that idea but expands the species-typical “machinery” beyond the enumerated foundations to narrative learning, motivation, social imitation, and collective coordination. The expanded list is not Moral Foundations Theory itself.

Active gene–environment correlation and gene–culture coevolution **Status: established mechanisms given a new target hypothesis.** Active gene–environment correlation comes from [Robert Plomin, John DeFries, and John Loehlin](#) and [Sandra Scarr and Kathleen McCartney](#); gene–culture coevolution was pioneered quantitatively by [L. Luca Cavalli-Sforza and Marcus Feldman](#) and developed by Boyd, Richerson, Henrich, and others. The present framework’s claim that these mechanisms may amplify and select differential **mythology receptivity** is a new, testable extension rather than an established result of those source theories.

Interpassivity **Status: borrowed and extended.** [Robert Pfaller](#), building on a line also associated with [Slavoj Žižek](#), uses interpassivity for delegated consumption, belief, or enjoyment. The present framework extends it to delegated moral and political performance. That extension is a hypothesis, not Pfaller’s established definition.

Paramorality **Status: borrowed, narrowed, and detached from its source theory.** The term is adapted from [Andrew M. Łobaczewski’s *Political Ponerology*](#). The present definition does not adopt Łobaczewski’s broader ponerological theory; it uses *paramorality* only for the observable reclassification of destructive gratification as moral conduct.

False consciousness **Status: borrowed and repurposed.** [Friedrich Engels](#) used “false consciousness” in his 1893 [letter to Franz Mehring](#) within a historical-materialist account of ideology. Here it is examined as a mythology-construction operation that can redescribe ordinary acceptance as evidence of capture. The present use is therefore not identical to Engels’s theory.

Repressive and liberating tolerance **Status: Marcuse’s terms, adversarial interpretation added here.** The expressions are Herbert Marcuse’s. His “[Repressive Tolerance](#)” supplies the object analysed here. **Qualified-concept alarm**, **semantic wrapper**, and **operational payload** name the present framework’s adversarial reading method rather than Marcuse’s own categories.

Suicidal empathy and the wood-cricket analogy **Status: borrowed example, theoretically extended.** **Suicidal empathy** and its application to “Queers for Palestine” are attributed to [Gad Saad](#). The present synthesis places the term inside egalitarian-guardian psychology, PCP, downhill mythology, and the distinction between carrier success and mythological replication. Saad’s political interpretation should not be confused with the [experimental biology of hairworm-infected crickets](#).

Mechanical solidarity **Status: source term retained; modifiers newly proposed.** [Émile Durkheim’s mechanical solidarity](#) is retained, while **first-order mechanical solidarity** and **lifted mechanical solidarity** are proposed extensions distinguishing shared concrete rules and answers from shared rules that generate, select, apply, and revise answers. Those modified expressions are not Durkheim’s. Plural civic integration is one proposed application of lifting rather than its definition.

Resonance **Status: common metaphor given a new technical definition.** The word is common across physics, sociology, cultural theory, and communication. Here it receives a precise three-component meaning: fit among species-typical machinery, heritable dispositional configuration, and mythological form.

Construction **Status: ordinary and cross-disciplinary term specified here.** The term shares family resemblance with social construction, discourse formation, framing, hegemony, cultural evolution, and institutional design. It does not imply that the object is unreal or that one designer controls the result.

Apologetics and polemics Status: theological terms generalized and functionally reassigned. [John G. Stackhouse](#) describes defensive apologetics as responding to challenges and offensive apologetics as provoking interest. [Friedrich Schleiermacher's Brief Outline of the Study of Theology](#) is an important source for treating apologetics and polemics as distinguishable sides of philosophical theology. The present framework borrows the ordinary defensive–contestatory contrast but changes the object: **mythological apologetics** defends and repairs any installed mythology, while **mythological polemics** attacks and unbraids a rival mythology. These operational meanings are not identical to Stackhouse's or Schleiermacher's theological classifications.

Psychoanalysis as unbraiding and propaganda as rebraiding Status: source practices joined by a new interpretive analogy. [Sigmund Freud's psychoanalysis](#) and [Edward Bernays's account of propaganda](#) are historical practices with their own objects and methods. The description of Freud as structured **untying** and Bernays as structured **weaving**, and the presentation of the two relatives as complementary programmers of the co-processor, belong to the present synthesis. They should not be attributed to either man as his self-description or treated as proof that Bernays merely applied Freud.

Critical Theory and cynical corrosion Status: source tradition retained; adversarial diagnosis added here. [Max Horkheimer's "Traditional and Critical Theory"](#) gives Critical Theory a positive rational and empirical orientation. The definition of a critical operation as delegitimizing a real institution against an impossible or unspecified ideal is the present framework's diagnosis of a **polemical failure mode**, not Horkheimer's definition and not a synonym for all Critical Theory. [Helen Pluckrose and James A. Lindsay's Cynical Theories](#) supplies related critical prior art concerning postmodern and activist theories. **Cynicism as corrosive acid, polemical corrosion**, and their position in the one-slot replacement model are formulations of the present synthesis rather than quotations from Pluckrose or Lindsay.

42. Newly proposed terms and formulations

The following terms should be attributed to the present synthesis unless independent prior use is established:

- **mythology construction** in the complete semantic sense defined here;
- **mythologies as the assembly language of the bigOther** as the originating analogy for evaluated narrative units close to the classifier's learned operations; it does not imply literal digital computation or narrative sufficiency;
- **resonant mythology construction** as its recipient-fit component;
- **Mythology Construction Toolkit**;
- **one-slot hypothesis** or **one-PCI-slot hypothesis** for exclusive occupancy by one local bigOther executing one operative weave, including compatible-package compositionality and unbraid/rebraid replacement under incompatibility;
- **mythology as braid, rope of logic, incumbent-braid map, and successor-braid map**;
- **braiding, unbraiding, and rebraiding** as the construction, dissolution, and replacement operations applied to mythology;
- **mythological apologetics** and **mythological polemics** as the generalized functions defined here;
- **apologetic slot, polemical slot, and systemic slot** as positions generated by a solidarity order;
- **actor-slot coupling** as the fit among disposition, preparation, symbolic credibility, recognition, and systemic function;
- **systemic actor selection** and the **natural-choice hypothesis** for how solidarity orders differentially recruit and ratify their characteristic defenders and attackers;
- **solidarity force field** as the E–M-field-inspired analogy joining mythological roles, social gradients, actor gravitation, and reciprocal field modification;
- **institutional apologetic actor** and **institutional polemical actor** for offices or organizations whose agency persists across individual representatives;
- **authority migration** from personal embodiment in first-order solidarity toward persistent office and institution in lifted solidarity;
- **actor-slot map** as a toolkit output;
- **mythological replacement cycle**: map → preserve → unbraid → bridge → rebraid → maintain;
- **trusted-opinion-leader capture followed by trusted-channel rebraiding** as the human-carrier form of the covert attack pattern in which an adversary gains influence through authenticated internal leaders and uses their authority to help install one successor weave; offices, institutions, appointment systems, and channels can be captured analogously without being classified as leaders;
- **sentinel inversion** for the limiting case in which a recognized guardian becomes the authenticated delivery channel for rival programming;

- **apologetic closure, polemical corrosion, and polemical vacancy;**
- **cynicism as corrosive acid** on an installed mythology;
- the **Freud–Bernays unbraiding/rebraiding analogy;**
- **culture mechanics** as the framework’s descriptive counterpart to mythology construction;
- **epistemic agency** and **epistemic constitution** in the specific operational senses defined here; the words have broader uses elsewhere, but no single external definition is being imported;
- **epistemic constitution of lifted mechanical solidarity;**
- **adversarial linguistic audit** as the framework’s combined inspection procedure;
- **three-component resonance model;**
- **observable resonance surface** in the specified multidimensional form;
- **cultural-meta-environment hypothesis;**
- **mythology family;**
- **producer–guardian model, egalitarian guardian,** and the proposed producer–guardian genetic-cluster hypothesis; the producer/guardian labels are loosely inspired by [Plato’s Republic](#), but the model itself is not Plato’s;
- **psychological gradient** as paired with drive direction;
- **psychologically downhill mythology** and **psychologically uphill mythology** in the present sense;
- **downhill honey trap;**
- **bundle of shared sublimations;**
- **mythology as education of psychological taste;**
- **coupling amplitude, coupling radius, and coupling thermostat** as social-mythological analogies;
- **marriage-mediated coupling-range hypothesis;**
- **genetic-hardware hypothesis** for lifted mechanical solidarity;
- **first-order mechanical solidarity** and **lifted mechanical solidarity;**
- **first-order full capture, lifted full capture,** the distinction between shared answers and a shared answer generator, and **universal jurisdiction over the allocation and limitation of first-order outputs and jurisdictions,** inherited from the coordinated theory project and applied to mythology construction here;
- **Babelization** as local mythological synchronization combined with society-wide semantic disintegration;
- **culture mixing as a Babel mechanism** under failed second-order integration;
- **reality-coupled mythology** as an explicit design category;
- **individual-sovereignty technology suite;**
- **adversarial mythology construction;**
- **dark artist** under the strict conduct-based definition given here;
- **qualified-concept alarm, semantic wrapper, and operational payload** as an adversarial semantic audit;
- **Perception–Context–Permission** as the causal-action routing sequence;
- the smoke-alarm maxim joining visible destruction, mythological analysis, and causal attribution.

43. Scope and ethical cautions

1. **Mythology does not mean falsehood.** A mythology can preserve truth, error, fiction, sacred commitment, and adaptive practical knowledge in one cultural form.
2. **Construction does not imply total control.** Recipients interpret, resist, combine, parody, and transform what they receive.
3. **Resonance does not establish truth or benefit.** It predicts cultural fit, not reality correspondence or moral worth.
4. **Failure to resonate does not establish falsity.** A true account may lack intelligible cultural form or demand an acquired taste.
5. **Genetic influence is probabilistic, polygenic, and population-sensitive.** It does not determine an individual and must not be inferred mechanically from group membership.
6. **Genetic hypotheses remain inside the theory.** Their current measurement limits define a research programme; they are not grounds for silently deleting the proposed mechanism.
7. **Population comparison requires rigorous design.** Score portability, stratification, indirect genetic effects, measurement invariance, and environmental difference must be addressed.
8. **Recipient adaptation is not a licence to deceive.** Compatible variants must converge on compatible operations and outcomes.
9. **Moral reframing is not automatically manipulation.** It becomes deceptive when it hides material contradiction, invents evidence, or promises incompatible worlds.
10. **Psychologically uphill does not mean maximally painful.** Difficulty is constructive only when it serves capability, relationship, creation, maintenance, truth, or posterity.

11. **Pleasure and ease are not inherently death-driven.** Rest, play, affection, and mastered virtue can replenish life or make good practice habitual.
12. **Sublimation is not identical to repression.** The framework asks how energy is transformed and whether the resulting form supports flourishing.
13. **Diversity is not Babelization.** Babelization concerns loss of society-wide semantic interoperability and legitimate common procedure.
14. **Democratic mismatch does not establish civilizational inferiority.** It predicts that institutions require cultural and dispositional coadaptation.
15. **Visible destruction is evidence for investigation, not proof of a chosen cause.** Rival causal stories must be tested.
16. **Dark artist is not a partisan label.** It requires demonstrable strategic conduct, knowledge, and causal responsibility.
17. **Deterrence is not vengeance.** Legitimate costs require evidence, proportionality, jurisdiction, and due process.
18. **Constructive mythology remains corrigible.** A mythology that exempts itself from its own epistemic safeguards has begun to become a dark art.
19. **The one-slot hypothesis is an architectural claim, not literal neuroanatomy.** People can hold multiple schemas, identities, stories, and represented alternatives, while one operative lens can braid several compatible packages. The claim denies parallel governing bigOthers and runtime ranking; incompatible governing capture requires rejection or unbraid/rebraid replacement.
20. **Polemics is not permission to lie or dehumanize.** Legitimate unbraiding attacks demonstrable claims, bindings, authority relations, practices, and consequences.
21. **Apologetics is not immunity from correction.** Defence becomes closure when every objection is reclassified as hostility and no evidence can loosen a strand.
22. **Negative critique is not automatically nihilistic.** Its quality depends on its evidence, feasible comparison, preserved goods, disclosed successor, and responsibility for transition costs.
23. **The Freud–Bernays symmetry is an analogy, not a complete causal history.** It clarifies complementary operations without collapsing psychoanalysis into deprogramming or propaganda into applied psychoanalysis.
24. **Natural choice is not predestination.** It predicts differential fit and recognition among available candidates, not one genetically destined officeholder.
25. **Systemic selection need not have a conscious selector.** “The system chooses” is shorthand for distributed attraction, filtering, training, appointment, imitation, reward, sanction, and collective recognition.
26. **Recognition does not establish truth or legitimacy.** A solidarity order can select gifted defenders of a false, corrupt, or death-driven mythology.
27. **Institutional agency does not erase human responsibility.** Institutions persist through offices and procedures, but identifiable humans still decide, speak, enforce, resist, and bear responsibility for their conduct.
28. **Self-appointment and self-preparation are different.** A person may deliberately prepare and compete for a role; what cannot be privately manufactured is the recognized systemic authority attached to the slot.
29. **Full, lifted, universal, and corrigible are not synonyms.** Full describes complete slot occupancy; lifted means that shared binding force lies in the generator rather than the generated concrete answers; universal describes how far that generator governs; and corrigible describes openness to inspection, succession, and reality’s right of refusal. Rival construction or replacement is not pathological merely because it is rival.
30. **Changed belief is not evidence of covert attack.** Capture of a trusted opinion leader or an institutional channel requires evidence of provenance, dependency, coordination, concealment, or control that defeats serious alternatives such as sincere conversion, intellectual development, new evidence, ordinary incentives, generational succession, and independent convergence.
31. **This toolkit is mythology-specific, not the definitive complete culture-implementation manual.** Use *Systems Leadership* for the exact practical method. Mythology has an elevated place as the bigOther’s assembly language, but systems, symbols, leadership behaviour, habits, and repeated experience may be equally necessary or more decisive in an implementation.

Semantic summary

- **Broader class:** deliberate cultural formation and institutional design.
- **Central object:** a connected mythology of causal stories, moral classifications, identities, roles, and expectations, together with its mythology-bearing relations to symbols, practices, systems, and institutions.
- **Elevated theoretical role:** mythologies are the **assembly language of the bigOther**—a privileged evaluated narrative interface, not the whole culture-implementation stack and not a sufficient cause by itself.
- **Immediate cultural mechanism:** training and activation of the mythological lens and bigOther.
- **Recipient-fit component:** resonant mythology construction.

- **Applied component:** the full mythology-specific Mythology Construction Toolkit, subordinate to the definitive whole-culture implementation method in *Systems Leadership*.
- **Resonance substrate:** species-typical human machinery plus heritable dispositional configuration.
- **Cultural-meta-environment:** distributed mythologies, institutions, peers, media, and public classifications that can produce patterned non-genetic formation beyond the shared household.
- **Observable interface:** expressed dispositions × moral intuitions × motives × causal worldview × group identity × authority structure × institutions × situation.
- **Construction grammar:** topoi, plot, causal stories, characters, sacred values, master signifiers, identity offers, role offers, and PCP.
- **Construction topology:** cross-bound strands of story, moral judgment, identity, symbol, role, ritual, institution, and material practice form a redundant rope of logic.
- **Single-slot constraint:** one local bigOther executes one operative mythological weave; no higher runtime process ranks parallel governing bigOthers.
- **Full-capture distinction:** a first-order program and a lifted meta-program can each completely occupy the one slot; fullness does not by itself imply closure.
- **Order-level distinction:** first-order solidarity shares concrete rules and answers; lifted solidarity shares rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers.
- **Lifted jurisdiction:** a shared answer generator may govern universally while constituting, allocating, limiting, coordinating, and governing the succession and correction of first-order outputs and jurisdictions.
- **Package compositionality:** several compatible religious, professional, familial, national, or local packages can be constituent strands of that one weave.
- **Replacement problem:** an incompatible governing mythology cannot be installed beside the incumbent; the incumbent must be unbraided sufficiently for one successor to be rebraided, installed, and made authoritative.
- **Defensive operation:** mythology-level apologetics explains, repairs, and renews the braid.
- **Offensive operation:** mythology-level polemics isolates and loosens false or destructive bindings while preserving recoverable strands.
- **Actor question:** apologetics and polemics are performed by persons, offices, or institutions recognized by the relevant solidarity order.
- **Authority scaling:** first-order solidarity tends toward personalized actors; lifted solidarity can locate durable agency in offices and institutions represented by replaceable humans.
- **Authority boundary:** the lifted meta-order is universal at its level, while its representative persons, offices, and institutions remain bounded and receive no ownership of all interpretation or reality.
- **Selection mechanism:** systemic slot × dispositional fit × preparation × collective or institutional ratification → actor-slot coupling.
- **Reciprocal field effect:** the solidarity field selects its characteristic actors, and those actors reinforce, redirect, or destabilize the field.
- **Entry question:** Why would this population recognize and adopt the mythology?
- **Momentum question:** Which path does the mythology make psychologically downhill or uphill?
- **Destination question:** Does repetition move toward life-drive creation or death-drive sterility and destruction?
- **Formative mechanism:** sublimation and education of psychological taste.
- **Durable implementation:** ritual, practice, selection, reward, sanction, institution, infrastructure, and memory.
- **Scale problem:** coupling strength and radius, lifted solidarity, coordination, synchronization, and Babelization.
- **Democracy mismatch hypothesis:** imported civic operations may fail when their mythology does not fit the population's dispositional and potentially genetic hardware.
- **Culture-mixing threshold:** incompatible first-order mythologies can multiply faster than a shared second-order mythology can integrate them.
- **Long feedback loop:** potentially fast gene-culture coevolution through niche selection, institution, status, partner choice, migration, fertility, survival, and reproduction.
- **Positive design ideal:** reality-coupled, life-drive mythology that grows capability and preserves correction.
- **Primary adversarial threat:** psychologically downhill mythology using dark arts to create dependency, dissipate energy, and disable maturation.
- **Semantic dark-art test:** strip the moral wrapper from qualified concepts and inspect the concrete permissions they authorize.
- **Carrier-replicator warning:** a mythology can reproduce successfully by inducing conduct that damages its human carriers.
- **Replacement sequence:** incumbent-braid map → polemical unbraiding → liminal bridge → successor braid → reality-coupled apologetics.
- **Covert replacement threat:** trusted-opinion-leader capture or analogous capture of an authority structure can invert trusted guardians, obscure provenance through nested internal channels, and convert vertical

authorization into horizontal field proof while rebraiding one successor; changed belief or disclosed payment alone is not proof.

- **Defensive sequence:** apologetic repair → immunization → superior constructive attractor → recovery → containment and deterrence.
- **Accountability rule:** sanctions attach to demonstrable conduct and causal responsibility.
- **Central normative distinction:** cultural replication is not identical to human or civilizational flourishing.

Example of use

The campaign succeeded at message distribution but failed as **mythology construction**. Its causal story resonated with the audience and produced rapid identity formation, yet it offered no reality-facing role, converted frustration into renewable demand, intensified local synchronization at the expense of civic solidarity, and protected itself from correction. It was therefore replicatively successful but psychologically downhill, institutionally corrosive, and weakly reality-coupled.

Compact formulas

Umbrella definition:

mythology construction = diagnose → articulate → braid → resonate → route → embody → coordinate → test → correct → defend → transmit

Assembly-language relation:

evaluated stories encode roles + causes + values + permissions + consequences → mythologies train general lens mappings → bigOther executes those mappings; systems + symbols + habits + conduct + repeated experience supply or disrupt the implementation environment

Single-slot composition:

compatible packages and libraries → cross-binding within one operative weave; incompatible governing program → rejection or unbraid/rebraid replacement, never runtime ranking of parallel bigOthers

Lifting and jurisdiction:

full capture by shared concrete answers → unbraid their claim to finality → rebraid shared M; fixed M + current K_t + situation C → binding R_t(C); M may govern universally while generating bounded first-order jurisdictions

Mythological replacement:

map incumbent braid → preserve sound strands → polemically unbraid false bindings → bridge the liminal interval → rebraid the successor → maintain through corrigible apologetics

Braided durability:

story × moral judgment × identity × symbol × role × ritual × institution × consequence → flexible and redundant rope of logic

Actor selection:

systemic slot × dispositional fit × preparation × symbolic credibility × recognition → effective apologetic or polemical actor

Authority scaling:

first-order solidarity → authoritative person embodies the mythology

lifted solidarity → universal meta-order persists through plural, bounded institutions and replaceable human representatives

Force-field reciprocity:

solidarity field selects actor ↔ actor reinforces or modifies solidarity field

Three-component resonance:

common human machinery × heritable dispositional configuration × mythological form → probability of adoption, retention, enactment, and transmission

Action routing:

mythological lens → causal story → Perception → Context → Permission → action

Downhill capture:

resonance → immediate reward → renewable demand → repetition → identity and dependency → rising exit cost

Life-drive formation:

resonance → chosen challenge → sublimation → capability and contribution → maintenance and posterity

Social range:

coupling amplitude + coupling radius → topology of trust, mythology, and cooperation

Babelization:

strong local coherence + weak intergroup semantic coupling → destruction of society-wide collective agency

Reality coupling:

mythology gives practice meaning → practice produces consequences → consequences correct mythology

Adversarial defence:

repair through apologetics + expose and unbraid through polemics + inoculate against the trick + build a superior attractor + preserve exit + impose conduct-based costs

Covert trusted-opinion-leader threat:

map trusted opinion leader and supporting authority structures → hidden influence or selection → preserve internal carrier identity → translate through incumbent language → nested cascade + visible peer uptake → institutionalize → rebraid one naturalized successor

Final contrast:

A destructive mythology makes gratification consume the future. A constructive mythology makes disciplined transformation create a future.